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<i>President:</i>	Mr. Kariuki/Mr. Phipps	(United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland)
<i>Members:</i>	Albania	Mr. Stastoli
	Brazil	Mr. Wazima Szatmari
	China	Mr. Yao Jialiang
	Ecuador	Mr. Gross Pozo
	France	Ms. Freudenreich
	Gabon	Mrs. Koumba Pambo
	Ghana	Ms. Barnor
	Japan	Mr. Ishikane
	Malta	Ms. Abela
	Mozambique	Mr. Afonso
	Russian Federation	Mr. Kuzmenkov
	Switzerland	Mrs. Chanda
	United Arab Emirates	Ms. Alshamsi
	United States of America	Ms. Trinh

Agenda

Women and peace and security

Conflict-related sexual violence: promoting implementation of Security Council resolutions on conflict-related sexual violence

Report of the Secretary-General on conflict-related sexual violence (S/2023/413)

Letter dated 26 June 2023 from the Permanent Representative of the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland to the United Nations addressed to the Secretary-General (S/2023/476)

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The meeting resumed at 3 p.m.

The President: I now give the floor to the Minister for Foreign Affairs, Education, and Sport of the Principality of Liechtenstein.

Ms. Hasler (Liechtenstein): It is my honour to address the Security Council today on a topic that is particularly dear to me. The women and peace and security agenda, including the protection and support of victims and survivors of conflict-related sexual violence, is a priority of Liechtenstein's foreign policy, and I am personally committed to the cause.

As a result of escalating violence, militarization and weakened rule of law protections, civilians bear the brunt of armed conflicts across the globe. Sexual violence is used as a weapon of war to attack civilian populations and to break societies, communities and families. Such violence is documented in virtually every conflict worldwide, including in Myanmar, Ukraine and Yemen. All those situations require the urgent attention of the respective accountability mechanisms. In the case of Ukraine, we will be looking for in particular expeditious investigations by the International Criminal Court (ICC).

I also want to highlight our appreciation for the briefing this morning by Naw Hser Hser, which reflects her tireless advocacy on behalf of the women of Myanmar. We were pleased to see the Security Council adopt resolution 2669 (2022) last December. Given the worsening situation on the ground, we believe that it is now time for the Council to seriously consider a follow-up text that will bring accountability for the crimes committed in Myanmar, including conflict-related sexual violence.

All acts of sexual violence are not only morally repugnant but also categorically prohibited under international humanitarian and human rights law. They constitute war crimes and may amount to crimes against humanity and genocide. Concrete, time-bound preventive measures, as explicitly outlined in resolutions 2106 (2013) and 2467 (2019), are necessary to bring an end to these atrocities. We reiterate our call on the Council to include conflict-related sexual violence as a designation criterion in targeted sanctions regimes. Such measures are in line with and complementary to the code of conduct of the Accountability, Coherence and Transparency Group regarding Security Council action against genocide, crimes against humanity and war crimes. The code of

conduct is now supported by 129 States, including the majority of the Council's membership.

Although widespread and often systematic, sexual violence against men and boys remains underreported owing to stigma, cultural taboo and a lack of criminalization. As a result, male survivors of sexual violence are often unable to access legal remedies, as well as medical and mental health services. The pioneering work by the Liechtenstein-based international non-governmental organization All Survivors Project has helped to advance awareness through tireless advocacy. Its work has informed resolution 2467 (2019), which has paved the way for strengthened accountability in that regard. The Council should consistently call on States to live up to their obligation to investigate and prosecute conflict-related sexual violence, in line with the primacy of national systems. The international justice system must be engaged where national systems fail owing to inability or unwillingness.

International criminal justice mechanisms have significantly advanced our efforts to fight impunity. The Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court — the twenty-fifth anniversary of which we celebrate on Monday — has played a vital role in ending impunity for sexual violence crimes. It is the first international criminal law instrument that explicitly recognizes forms of sexual violence, such as rape, sexual slavery, enforced prostitution and enforced sterilization, as distinct war crimes and crimes against humanity. It urges States parties to appoint judges with special legal expertise on gender-based violence and requests the Court to provide special protection to victims, including with regard to age and gender.

In practice, the ICC has done pioneering work to hold perpetrators to account by establishing a comprehensive and victim-centred framework. It has firmly established conflict-related sexual and gender-based violence as crimes against humanity and war crimes. We commend the office of the Prosecutor for including charges related to sexual and gender-based crimes in many of their cases and for prioritizing those crimes as a matter of policy. The case of Bosco Ntaganda resulted in a milestone verdict as sexual violence crimes committed against males were held to the same standards as those committed against females. The ICC's judgment against Dominic Ongwen also succeeded in painting a comprehensive picture of sexual and gender-based crimes suffered by victims

and constitutes an important precedent for future cases. Dedicated gender expertise in investigative teams, including our partners from Justice Rapid Response, is crucial for the ICC and other regional and international accountability mechanisms in that regard.

No person should ever have to go through the terrifying and traumatizing experience of conflict-related sexual violence. We must therefore redouble our efforts to prevent its occurrence. At the root of it, that means combating structural gender inequality and promoting the participation and leadership of women in public life. By ensuring women's rights to full, equal and meaningful participation, we contribute to the prevention of conflict-related sexual violence and to the health of our societies, as a whole.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Poland.

Ms. Skoczek (Poland): Poland thanks the United Kingdom for convening this important debate and for its efforts to advance the implementation of the relevant Security Council resolutions. We also thank the Secretary-General for his comprehensive report on the issue (S/2023/413) and lend our support to the mandate and activities of Special Representative of the Secretary-General Pramila Patten.

Poland aligns itself with the statements made on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security.

The use of sexual violence as a weapon or tactic of war is widespread. Conflict-related sexual violence remains a significant global concern, primarily affecting women and girls, but we should not forget to account for the male victims, as well. Poland stands in solidarity with all victims and survivors and calls for greater support that encompasses the recognition of their suffering, the elimination of stigma and the provision of medical and psychosocial assistance. Impunity and the lack of accountability have allowed conflict-related sexual violence to persist. By holding perpetrators accountable, we can send a powerful message to victims and survivors that their voices have been heard, and to offenders that the days of empty warnings are over.

Poland emphasizes the significance of women's participation in processes aimed at addressing sexual violence, including peace talks. Female negotiators can ensure a survivor-centred approach, facilitate

the rehabilitation of survivors, secure post-conflict reparations, promote accountability and establish vetting mechanisms to exclude perpetrators from security forces. We support peacekeeping and monitoring missions to provide adequate protection for all victims. In that vein, we endorse the deployment of women's protection advisers and the use of early-warning indicators to address conflict-related sexual violence.

As a neighbour of Ukraine, currently hosting the largest community of Ukrainian refugees, Poland condemns the deliberate use of sexual violence by Russian soldiers as a tactic of war and intimidation. We welcome the reference to those appalling practices in the report. The massive displacement caused by Russian aggression has heightened the risks of all forms of sexual violence. In response, Poland has swiftly implemented new measures to support Ukrainian citizens seeking refuge in our country, which Special Representative of the Secretary-General Patten kindly referred to in her briefing. Since the consequences of conflict-related sexual violence extend beyond the physical dimension and have lasting impacts on survivors' lives, effective prevention and multisectoral response mechanisms are crucial in post-conflict settings. Mindful of that, Poland's Ministry of Health has initiated an intensive therapy pilot programme aimed at providing trauma treatment for women survivors in conflict and post-conflict environments.

Accountability is essential to ensure compliance with international obligations. Failure to take decisive action will only encourage further abuse. Consequently, Poland actively assists the International Criminal Court in collecting evidence of war crimes committed by Russia in Ukraine. To that end, we have established a joint investigation team with Lithuania and Ukraine. In addition, the Raphael Lemkin Center for Documenting Russian Crimes in Ukraine has been established in Warsaw. Its purpose is to gather and preserve evidence of war crimes and crimes against humanity and to record witness testimonies. There are numerous unreported cases for each one that comes to light. We have the moral obligation to support the courageous survivors who have come forward, as well as those who have been silenced by fear.

The President: I should like to remind all speakers to limit their statements to no more than three minutes in order to enable the Council to carry out its work expeditiously. Flashing lights on the collars of the

microphones will prompt speakers to bring their remarks to a close after three minutes.

I now give the floor to the representative of Algeria.

Mr. Gaouaoui (Algeria) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I would like to thank the United Kingdom for holding this debate on a very critical topic that continues to have serious implications, owing to the spread of armed conflicts and the related brutal and inhumane atrocities involving women and girls in particular.

My country, Algeria, reiterates its condemnation in the strongest terms all forms of sexual violence against women and girls in all their forms and manifestations and in all circumstances. Such practices are unequivocally rejected and have no place in our present or future world. We believe in the importance of combating all forms of violence, particularly those that target women and girls. Consequently, Algeria ratified all international conventions on combating violence against women in response to their aspirations and to establish a culture and values that counter all forms of women's marginalization and to guarantee their participation in sustainable development.

Since 2007, Algeria has been a pioneer in developing its national strategy to combat violence against women and girls, which includes three areas of intervention: tailoring services; mobilizing society and achieving social and national solidarity; and building alliances. In line with that strategy, we conduct regular training sessions for the judiciary, the gendarmerie and the police to ensure its effective implementation. Furthermore, we have updated laws to protect women from all forms of violence, while adopting a number of protection mechanisms that have been implemented in coordination with various sectors at the local level, in civil society and in the media. Moreover, we have promoted the legislation to curb violence against women, which reflects the political will at the highest levels in the country, including by adding a provision in the Constitution that condemns violence against women and makes it incumbent upon the State to protect women everywhere and under all circumstances.

During this debate, we are discussing how to implement the existing commitments and frameworks, particularly those adopted by the Security Council, as set forward in the report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/413), along with its valuable recommendations.

Algeria, as a State, has worked to establish a robust and integrated arsenal of laws and policies to combat violence against women and girls. We will work both within and outside the Council to combat that phenomenon, especially during times of conflict, to bring about a world free from violence. We also highly value the role of women in resolving conflicts and overcoming their repercussions. The resilience and effective participation of Algerian women played an important role in fighting terrorism in the 1990s. Thanks to their participation, Algeria was able to overcome that destructive scourge.

Based on our national experience in combating violence against women, I would like to underscore the following points.

First, we need to update legal frameworks and national laws so that they correspond to current developments in the world involving the spread of conflicts and their changing nature. They must be in line with the international community's adopted instruments, especially the relevant Security Council resolutions.

Secondly, we need to implement the relevant Security Council resolutions, of which there are many, beginning with resolution 1820 (2008) and through resolution 2467 (2019). As the consecutive reports of the Secretary-General demonstrate, sexual violence in times of armed conflict continues to persist. We therefore must take measures to guarantee the implementation of those resolutions by including their provisions in the mandates of peacekeeping operations and consistently punishing perpetrators. Security forces must protect women from all forms of sexual violence during conflicts.

Thirdly, we need to adopt a comprehensive approach so that, in particular, protecting women from sexual violence in times of conflict is not limited to a specific entity. We need concerted efforts by all actors, including State institutions, international organizations, the United Nations and civil society to put in place a robust legislative, security and legal system that curbs the phenomenon and addresses it effectively.

Fourthly, victims of sexual violence must be guaranteed timely access to justice through effective grievance mechanisms, measures to provide compensation for damages and comprehensive reparations processes.

Fifthly, impunity must be prevented, since, unfortunately, as the Secretary-General emphasized in his report, “in most contexts, impunity remained the norm” (S/2023/413, p. 4). Therefore, in order to ensure that all those who have perpetrated acts of sexual violence against women are punished, it is necessary to enshrine the principle of the rule of law and build strong national institutions, at various levels, to reduce the risk of women and girls being subjected to conflict-related sexual violence.

Sixthly, the root causes of conflict-related sexual violence must be addressed by taking the measures necessary to tackle the structural causes that make women vulnerable and more subject to sexual violence during conflicts, especially poverty, the collapse of State institutions and lack of development. To that end, conscious policies should be adopted that take into account the needs of women and promote women’s meaningful participation in political, development and security institutions.

Putting an end to sexual violence in times of conflict is a top priority and a moral and political imperative incumbent upon us all. It is unacceptable that the dignity of women and girls is undermined while we are not able to address that scourge and punish the perpetrators. The best defence against conflict-related sexual violence is to build a society in which social justice and equal opportunities reign and in which all women and girls enjoy their rights and equal protection under the law.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Croatia.

Mr. Šimonović (Croatia): I thank the United Kingdom presidency for organizing this debate and the briefers for sharing valuable insights.

Croatia aligns itself with the statements made on behalf of the European Union, the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security and the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect.

I would also like to add some remarks in my national capacity.

As we mark the fifteenth anniversary of the Security Council resolution which condemned the use of sexual violence as a weapon of war, the Secretary-General’s report for 2022 (S/2023/413) shows that it still remains one of the most widespread human rights violations in conflict-affected countries. We must do everything we

can to improve prevention, protect survivors and punish perpetrators. In that regard, let me thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict for her tireless efforts.

Sexual violence in conflict is closely related to discrimination against women and sexual violence in peacetime. In many countries, impunity prevails owing to a reluctance to prosecute crimes of sexual violence. This is added to the number of crimes that have already gone unreported, as survivors fear retaliation or social stigma. We strongly encourage all States to align their laws with international humanitarian and human rights law, especially the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women and the jurisprudence of the Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women, and to monitor their compliance with the relevant Security Council resolutions.

Tackling structural gender inequality should be prioritized in times of peace in order to minimize its effects during periods of instability. We also need to focus on a survivor-centred approach. As an example of such a practice, Croatian survivors of sexual violence suffered in the Homeland War are entitled to financial compensation and psychological support even if the perpetrators were never identified or brought to justice.

Finally, we fully support the use by the Security Council of sanctions against all parties, including mercenaries and private military companies, to prevent the recurrence of conflict-related sexual violence.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Mexico.

Mrs. Buenrostro Massieu (Mexico) (*spoke in Spanish*): We thank the United Kingdom for convening this annual open debate on conflict-related sexual violence and express our appreciation for the statements made thus far.

While Mexico recognizes the progress made since the adoption of Security Council resolution 1820 (2008) and subsequent resolutions, as well as the codification of sexual crimes as atrocities in the Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court, unfortunately, those violations of international humanitarian law and international human rights law persist and have even worsened in situations such as those in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Ethiopia, Haiti and South

Sudan, as highlighted in the most recent report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/413).

In that regard, Mexico wishes to underscore three calls to action.

First, it is crucial to ensure access to justice and health-care services, including sexual and reproductive health care and mental health care for victims and survivors. In conflict contexts, doing so entails providing holistic support to facilitate the reintegration of survivors and ensure that there is no impunity. It is important to recognize the importance of gender-responsive, timely and sufficient mental health and psychosocial support, which is necessary not only for survivors, but also for United Nations peacekeeping personnel. We call on the Council to make further progress on the provisions contained in resolution 2668 (2022).

Secondly, we must support the deployment of women's protection advisers in peace operations and transition processes. Women's protection advisers help to prevent atrocities and provide a timely response. It is also important to address discrimination against women, lack of representation and lack of services for survivors, which exacerbates the disproportionate impact of sexual violence on women and girls.

Thirdly, a year ago the presidencies of Ireland, Kenya and Mexico committed to making the women and peace and security agenda a priority in the Council. Since then, eight Council members who have served as President, including the United Kingdom, have signed a statement of shared commitments on that agenda. We urge all Security Council members to continue to commit to the women and peace and security agenda. In addition, further progress is needed in the collection and analysis of gender-disaggregated data to improve our understanding of specific needs and the multiple and intersectional forms of discrimination.

In conclusion, Mexico reiterates the importance of addressing conflict-related sexual violence in a preventive manner and promoting and ensuring the effective participation of women in decision-making.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Guatemala.

Ms. Rodríguez Mancia (Guatemala) (*spoke in Spanish*): Guatemala thanks the United Kingdom for convening this important open debate, and thanks Ms. Pramila Patten, Special Representative of the

Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict, and especially Nadine and Ms. Naw Hser Hser for their actions to save future generations from this scourge.

My delegation aligns itself with the statement delivered on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect, and I would like to highlight a few points in our national capacity.

Sexual violence in conflict is a devastating phenomenon with harmful consequences for the victims. Women and girls are those who are exposed to greater risks as a result of that scourge, which is used as a tactic of war, torture and terrorism in the midst of political and security crises that are becoming increasingly severe and common, causing displacement, the separation of families and the disappearance of loved ones.

That situation not only contravenes the rules of international humanitarian law but also undermines human dignity, significantly exacerbates and prolongs conflict situations, tears apart the social fabric and hinders reconstruction efforts.

My delegation has repeatedly condemned violence against women and children in conflict situations, including sexual violence, and called on all parties to armed conflict to cease such acts with immediate effect. Regrettably, such actions continue to occur, and some situations have become systemic and widespread, reaching an alarming degree of brutality.

According to the Secretary-General's report (S/2023/413), regrettably, the level of compliance by the parties to conflict with applicable international norms remains disappointing, despite efforts by the Council to establish sound regulatory frameworks. That is evidenced by the devastating illegal, unjustified and unprovoked aggression by the Russian Federation against Ukraine, which continues to result in increased loss of life, the denial of humanitarian access and a heightened risk of sexual violence and human trafficking because of mass internal displacement. The data from the investigations conducted by the Independent International Commission of Inquiry on Ukraine is alarming, and it is inconceivable that girls under the age of four are victims of those serious crimes.

We commend the work conducted by the Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict in setting up the inter-agency working group to address the issues

of human trafficking, the provision of assistance to survivors, access to justice and reparations.

We urge the Council to implement sanctions and promote a commitment to addressing sexual violence in armed conflict. We believe that sanctions can be used as a tool to prevent and stop sexual violence in armed conflict and address impunity for perpetrators.

In conclusion, we believe that the New Agenda for Peace must incorporate strong measures that address the root causes of the use of sexual violence in conflict, the prevention of such violence and attendant new threats identified by the Special Representative, including the digital element. It is everyone's responsibility to protect populations from that scourge.

The President: I give the floor to the representative of Costa Rica.

Ms. Chan Valverde (Costa Rica) (*spoke in Spanish*): Costa Rica deplores the fact that impunity for sexual violence in armed conflict continues to be the norm and that justice continues to elude victims and survivors, from Myanmar to Ukraine, and from Yemen to Haiti. In that regard, allow me to make three points.

First, the proliferation and illicit flow of small arms and light weapons and their ammunition contribute to and perpetuate sexual violence in conflict and post-conflict settings, thereby exacerbating the vulnerability of individuals. Consequently, disarmament and arms control are a key approach to preventing and addressing such atrocities, as indeed acknowledged in the United Nations Framework for the Prevention of Conflict-Related Sexual Violence. However, more must be done to define the practical links between disarmament and arms control and the women and peace and security agenda, in particular at the multilateral level. Costa Rica calls on the Council to promote and include disarmament and arms control considerations in its discussions and decisions on women and peace and security to further advance the agenda's implementation. At the practical level, Costa Rica calls for greater harmonization between national strategies for implementing the women and peace and security agenda and those for regulating small arms and light weapons, by integrating small arms and light weapons control practices in women and peace and security national action plans and women and peace and security considerations in small arms and light weapons national action plans. That could constitute a launching pad for furthering those efforts at the global scale.

Secondly, conflict-related sexual violence is not just a women's issue, but a security issue with much wider peace and security implications. Not only can rape serve as a precursor to conflict, a diagnosis of pre-conflict conditions and a symptom of impunity, but it is also evidence of a weak and deficient security sector. A robust security sector will indubitably support women's participation and improve the protection mechanisms needed to eliminate sexual violence in and out of conflict.

Thirdly, all resolutions under the women and peace and security umbrella are focused more on protecting women's bodies than on unleashing women's full potential. We must do more to redefine that agenda, such as by drafting a new stand-alone draft resolution that reframes education bans as a new form of structural violence against women and girls.

It is critical that survivors remain at the heart of our efforts. We must recognize that survivors have differing needs and may face multiple and intersecting forms of discrimination. We must ensure that their rights are protected, they are treated with dignity, they are able to access to justice and that they can safely, fully and meaningfully participate in decision-making at all levels.

The President: I give the floor to the representative of Colombia.

Mrs. Zalabata Torres (Colombia) (*spoke in Spanish*): We thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Armed Conflict, Pramila Patten, for her briefing and, in particular, for her support for Colombia's efforts to prevent and eliminate sexual violence in our country.

In Colombia, as in other parts of the world, that form of violence disproportionately affects women and girls, who account for 92.6 per cent of all victims and are overwhelmingly of African descent. LGBTIQ+ people and people with diverse gender identities and sexual orientations have also been subjected to sexual violence of various kinds that seek to impose heteronormativity.

With a view to advancing the elimination and prevention of sexual violence, the Government of President Gustavo Petro Urrego is taking several actions.

First, Colombia is in the process of developing its first feminist foreign policy. It is a pacifist, participatory and intersectional policy that has at its core the fight against gender-based violence, including, in particular,

sexual violence that occurs within and outside the context of armed conflict.

Secondly, after 23 years of indecision, Colombia is working on its first national action plan on resolution 1325 (2000) — a project that has been tirelessly supported by UN-Women and various civil society organizations. That process has six regional forums, of which four have already taken place, and a large national forum with women from all over the country. It also has territorial and sectoral forums with indigenous women, lesbian, bisexual and transgender women, women signatories of the peace process, victims and women of the diaspora.

Thirdly, the Final Agreement for Ending the Conflict and Building a Stable and Lasting Peace establishes clear and measurable commitments that seek not only to integrate the gender perspective in peacebuilding, but also to comprehensively address violence against women in all its forms. In addition to developing specific strategies aimed at emotional recovery for victims of sexual violence and psychosocial rehabilitation, in particular for victims of sexual violence, the Special Jurisdiction for Peace made the critical decision to open a macro-case to specifically address sexual and gender-based violence during armed conflict.

Fourthly, we are committed to the purposes and activities of the international Alliance on Preventing Sexual Violence in Conflict, within the framework of which we have implemented security policies with a preventive approach and training spaces for public servants and civil society.

I conclude by emphasizing that the full guarantee of human security that underpins Colombia's "total peace" policy is based on the fundamental premise that victims and survivors must be at the centre of all our efforts.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Austria.

Mr. Almoslechner (Austria): Austria aligns itself with the statements made on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security.

We commend the United Kingdom for its efforts to organize the annual open debate on conflict-related sexual violence and thank Special Representative of the Secretary-General Pramila Patten for presenting the annual report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/413).

Let me also thank the civil society briefers for sharing their perspectives.

Over the past 15 years, the Security Council has established a robust framework of applicable international norms addressing conflict-related sexual violence based on the condemnation of sexual violence as a tool of war and the recognition that rape and other forms of sexual violence can constitute war crimes, crimes against humanity or a constitutive act with respect to genocide. However, both the annual report and today's briefers paint a dismal picture with regard to compliance with those standards. Rape, sexual slavery, forced prostitution, forced pregnancy, forced abortion, enforced sterilization, forced marriage and other abhorrent forms of sexual violence continue to be used in situations linked to conflict throughout the world, including as a systematic tactic of war.

While women and girls are the primary targets, it is important to recognize that men, boys and persons with diverse gender identities are also affected. Sexual and gender-based violence is unacceptable in any circumstance and is particularly despicable when used in a widespread, targeted manner, which dramatically affects not only the immediate victims, but also their entire families and communities, as well as generations to come.

Austria is appalled by the report's findings of persisting and even worsening patterns of sexual violence in many different contexts, including in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Ethiopia, Haiti and South Sudan. We deplore the use of sexual and gender-based violence against civilians and prisoners of war as a result of Russia's unprovoked and unjustified war on Ukraine, which has been documented extensively by the United Nations human rights monitoring mission in Ukraine and the Independent International Commission of Inquiry on Ukraine, based in Vienna. Austria also remains deeply concerned about the situation in Afghanistan, where the Taliban de facto authorities have effectively erased women and girls from public life.

We strongly condemn all forms of conflict-related sexual violence and join the Secretary-General's call on all parties to conflict to immediately cease such crimes, comply with the relevant Security Council resolutions and allow unhindered access to United Nations teams. In particular, we call upon the Russian Federation, all listed parties and other perpetrators to make and

implement specific time-bound commitments to combat sexual violence in line with their international obligations and the recommendations contained in the report.

The most effective way to prevent conflict-related sexual violence is through strong compliance with the rule of law, which is also an indispensable precondition for sustainable peace and security. Therefore, we commend the Team of Experts on the Rule of Law and Sexual Violence in Conflict for continuing to assist national authorities in over a dozen countries in strengthening rule of law institutions to enhance accountability for conflict-related sexual violence.

Each State is responsible for ensuring accountability and access to justice for victims of conflict-related sexual violence. It is crucial to ensure that perpetrators are swiftly tried and held accountable. In that regard, we reiterate our full support to the International Criminal Court and to United Nations-mandated commissions of inquiry. Moreover, we wish to remind Member States of their obligation, in accordance with resolution 2467 (2019), to apply a survivor-centred approach and provide access to medical and psychosocial care.

Austria applauds Special Representative of the Secretary-General Pramila Patten for all her efforts to fulfil her mandate by working with Member States and armed groups towards compliance with international law, international humanitarian law, human rights law and international norms. We also commend UN-Women, which we strongly support, including in Ukraine and Afghanistan, and the United Nations Population Fund. We have also renewed our support to the United Nations Trust Fund to End Violence against Women this year. The immeasurable contributions of civil society organizations, in particular of women's and women-led organizations, in preventing and responding to conflict-related sexual violence also deserve to be emphasized.

We stand in solidarity with all victims of conflict-related sexual violence and their families. Accordingly, we urge the members of the Security Council to take bolder actions, including the use of sanctions, in order to address conflict-related sexual violence and, ultimately, to stop blatant breaches of international law, resolve conflicts and find solutions towards achieving sustainable peace and security. As a staunch supporter of resolution 1325 (2000), which was adopted by the Council 23 years ago, and in view of the discussions

on a New Agenda for Peace, Austria calls upon all Security Council members to collectively recommit to reinvigorating the women and peace and security agenda and instil new life into its implementation.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Greece.

Mr. Sekeris (Greece): Greece would like to warmly thank the United Kingdom for organizing today's timely event and the speakers for their thorough interventions. We welcome in particular the presence of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict, Ms. Pramila Patten.

While fully aligning myself with the statements made by the representative of the European Union and on behalf of the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security, allow me to make some additional remarks in my national capacity.

Despite systematic efforts by the United Nations system to strengthen the normative framework on conflict-related sexual violence, the latest report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/413) clearly illustrates a gap between standards and commitments and the devastating reality on the ground. In many conflict environments, the parties to conflict, whether State or non-State actors, continue to deploy the strategic use of conflict-related sexual violence against civilians — mostly women and girls, but also men and boys, as well as against members of the LGBTIQ+ communities.

The alarming frequency of conflict-related sexual violence and the prevailing impunity for those crimes, which is the norm rather than the exception, indicate rather low levels of compliance by States with the United Nations normative framework. Against that backdrop, there is undeniably an urgent need for holistic and coherent international policy action.

In that vein, the international response to conflict-related sexual violence should be inclusive and survivor-centred, addressing the specific needs of different groups of survivors, focusing on their protection, relief and recovery and therefore ensuring their full and meaningful participation in peace and transitional justice processes. At the same time, accountability for perpetrators should be adequately addressed by facilitating their prosecution through appropriate judicial mechanisms and by ensuring unhindered

judicial access and gender-responsive reparations for victims.

Conflict-related sexual violence is a horrific crime with devastating consequences for civilians, their families and their communities at large, a threat to security and an impediment to the restoration of peace. In that regard, Greece supports a human-centred and gender-responsive approach to peace and security that focuses primarily on the protection of civilians in conflict settings, especially women and children — girls and boys. That is also reflected in the priorities of the Greek candidacy for an elected seat on the Security Council for 2025–2026, which include the promotion of the interlinked agendas on the protection of civilians; women and peace and security; and children and armed conflict.

In that vein, I would like to reiterate my country's determination to join hands with all like-minded stakeholders in order to accelerate the prevention of and response to any form of conflict-related sexual violence as the only way to build peaceful, resilient, inclusive and gender-equal societies.

The President: We still have 40 names remaining on the list of speakers, so I would encourage speakers to limit their statements to three minutes, as our Greek colleague just did.

I now give the floor to the representative of Malaysia.

Mrs. Zin Zawawi (Malaysia): At the outset, my delegation would like to express our appreciation to the United Kingdom for convening this important debate. Malaysia would also like to thank the briefers for their updates and assessments.

I will try to be brief.

Malaysia condemns the abhorrent use of sexual violence as a tactic of war, torture and terrorism. We are gravely concerned with the reported heightened risk of sexual violence against civilians, particularly women and children in conflict. The recent report of the Secretary-General on conflict-related sexual violence (S/2023/413) presents disturbing findings on patterns of sexual violence that have persisted and further deepened in conflict situations. Against that background, we are dismayed by the prevalent impunity, with perpetrators quite regularly avoiding formal accountability.

Efforts to address sexual violence in conflict situations should employ an integrated and holistic approach by all important stakeholders, including States, the entire United Nations system and civil society. It is critical for countries in conflict and post-conflict situations to take adequate and necessary measures to prevent and respond to conflict-related sexual violence. In that regard, my delegation would like to highlight the following points.

First, it is incumbent on States to introduce or strengthen legislation and judicial processes to document, investigate and prosecute sexual violence in conflict and post-conflict situations. Importantly, the duty of States to ensure accountability must be embedded in both domestic and international law. All States have an obligation to prohibit conflict-related sexual violence and prosecute the perpetrators. We also call for provisions concerning conflict-related sexual violence to be integrated into the negotiations and agreements of peace processes.

Secondly, we see merit in broadening networking and coordination between the Security Council and the Human Rights Council with the aim of ensuring accountability for violations, including sexual assault and violence against women and children.

Thirdly, the meaningful participation of women in prevention efforts, peacekeeping and peacebuilding should be prioritized. When women have a role as agents of change in the security framework, it can enhance citizens' trust in institutions and contribute to improving intelligence-gathering, the reporting of gender-based violence and treatment for victims, witnesses and suspects. At the same time, we need to end harassment and reprisals targeting women in peace and security processes.

Malaysia remains committed to the women and peace and security agenda and to collective efforts to combat conflict-related sexual violence, including through United Nations peacekeeping operations. The Malaysian Peacekeeping Centre has been teaching courses on gender and on the role of women in peacekeeping missions since 2014. The elimination of conflict-related sexual violence is our collective moral duty. Let me conclude by stressing how important it is for the Council to work with the relevant stakeholders and partners in our efforts to strengthen the protection of civilians, including women and children, in conflict situations.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Sierra Leone.

Mr. Turay (Sierra Leone): The delegation of Sierra Leone is pleased to join this global discourse on the theme of promoting the implementation of Security Council resolutions on conflict-related sexual violence. I would also like to congratulate your country on assuming the presidency of the Council for the month of July, Mr. President, and I thank you for convening this timely debate.

Having experienced one of the bloodiest and fiercest civil wars in recent history, during which sexual violence, including rape, sexual slavery and forced marriage, was used as a tactic of war by the warring factions, Sierra Leone is fully aware of the horrifying impact of such crimes on the lives and livelihoods of its women and girls and will spare no effort to combat that scourge.

While there is no gainsaying the fact that many commendable actions have been taken by both the General Assembly and the Council in the form of treaties, conventions and resolutions, including resolution 1820 (2008), women and children around the world remain vulnerable to sexual violence, whether in times of war or peace. There is still much to be done at the national, subregional, regional and global levels if we are to fully implement the landmark resolutions 1325 (2000) and 1820 (2008) and other relevant human rights instruments in our grand efforts to turn the tide against sexual violence in all its forms and manifestations.

Building on our domestic efforts, in his address to the General Assembly in September 2021 (see A/76/PV.6), President Bio called for global solidarity on access to justice, remedies and assistance for survivors of sexual violence in the form of a stand-alone resolution, which the Assembly adopted by consensus as resolution 76/304 on 2 September 2022. That resolution not only highlights the gravity of sexual violence, but specifically calls out such crimes as abhorrent and destructive of international peace and security and seeks to lift up survivors, who deserve dignity and justice. I encourage all Member States to implement the resolution's directives, as most of its elements speak to the issues of accountability and prevention. In our view, peace is not merely the absence of visible conflict, and in order to have true peace, survivors must have access to justice.

Let me conclude by appealing to everyone here today to reflect deeply on the fact that notwithstanding the many stringent measures that have been adopted both individually and collectively in this area, the despicable crime of conflict-related violence, especially sexual violence, has continued unabated around the world, and often with total impunity. The time to accelerate efforts is now, and concerted and concrete steps need to be taken urgently to address the incidence of crimes of sexual violence and to restore the dignity of survivors, including by promoting forward-looking strategies and strengthening accountability and prevention by enforcing compliance with the relevant normative positions that we are all agreed on.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Slovenia.

Ms. Jurečko (Slovenia): We thank the United Kingdom for organizing today's debate. Slovenia aligns itself with the statements made on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security, respectively, as well as the statement to be delivered on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect.

We welcome the Secretary-General's annual report (S/2023/413) and its presentation. Slovenia condemns in absolute terms the use of sexual violence as a tactic of war or as an instrument of repression and intimidation, and calls for the full implementation of the commitments to end it. With a focus on the prevention of sexual violence in situations directly or indirectly linked to a conflict, we would like to underline the following three points.

First, impunity encourages the continued commission of such crimes, as evidenced by the fact that a sizeable majority of the same perpetrators appear in these reports year after year. Supporting and investing in strong justice systems and rule-of-law institutions are essential to prosecuting and punishing the perpetrators and those responsible. To that end, Slovenia would also support listing sexual violence as a stand-alone criterion for targeted sanctions by the relevant Sanctions Committees.

Secondly, we need to resolutely address barriers to reporting, monitoring and documenting this crime. In that regard, we believe it is vital to ensure humanitarian access; the accelerated deployment of women's protection advisers in all relevant situations of concern, in line with resolution 2467 (2019); the provision of comprehensive and tailored support to

survivors of sexual violence and children born of such violence and close work with the affected communities to address stigma, socioeconomic isolation and the fear of retaliation.

Thirdly, we need to encourage and facilitate the full, equal and meaningful participation of women in humanitarian, recovery, political, peace, security and development processes. That is also essential to ensuring the availability and safeguarding of gender-based violence services.

In conclusion, Slovenia underlines its enduring support for the work and mandate of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict. We will continue to work with partners such as UN-Women, the International Committee of the Red Cross, the United Nations Population Fund and the Women's Peace and Humanitarian Fund to address the needs of survivors of sexual violence in conflict and support the work of human rights defenders and activists on this matter.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Ukraine.

Ms. Hayovyshyn (Ukraine): I thank the United Kingdom presidency of the Council for organizing this important open debate and Special Representative Pramila Patten for her insightful briefing. I am especially grateful to the briefers, Ms. Naw Hser Hser and Nadine, for sharing their testimonies and practical recommendations with us today.

My delegation aligns itself with the statements made on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security, respectively, and I would also like to make a few points in my national capacity.

The Secretary-General's report (S/2023/413) reveals a distressing reality. Both State and non-State armed groups extensively employ conflict-related sexual violence, targeting civilians through rape, gang rape and abductions. Those findings once again demonstrate that the Russian Federation persistently uses sexual violence as a weapon of war against Ukraine. Prosecutors and investigators have documented 212 cases of such crimes, including 13 involving children — 12 girls and one boy. Those atrocities span a wide age range, from the youngest victim, at the tender age of four, to the oldest survivor, aged 87. The United Nations has reported sexual violence used as a form of torture and

inhumane treatment against civilians and prisoners of war. It is crucial to recognize that those numbers represent only cases in which survivors were able and willing to testify, suggesting that the actual figures are much higher.

Ukraine remains committed to replacing impunity with justice and transforming indifference into action. The experiences, needs and demands of survivors are at the heart of our efforts. We commend the efforts of Special Representative Patten and her team, who have provided substantial assistance to the Government of Ukraine in achieving those goals. Last year, we signed a framework of cooperation with the United Nations to respond to and prevent conflict-related sexual violence, becoming the first country to establish an all-encompassing coordination mechanism for combating conflict-related sexual violence. Shortly after that, Ukraine adopted a detailed implementation plan involving State institutions, civil society and international organizations. In partnership with the United Nations Population Fund, we opened 11 survivor relief centres across the country to provide victims with access to various services. To structure and ensure the effectiveness of that cooperation, we have established an inter-agency working group, which focuses on five key areas: access to justice and accountability, comprehensive assistance to survivors of conflict-related sexual violence, strengthening the security and defence sector to prevent conflict-related sexual violence, combating trafficking in persons for sexual exploitation and reparations and compensation.

Another crucial step is gaining political commitments and leading the international legal battle for justice. Ukraine joined the International Alliance on Preventing Sexual Violence in Conflict initiative, launched by the United Kingdom, and proudly became a Vice-Chair. We firmly believe that solid cooperation among Governments, multilateral partners, civil society and survivors is a crucial prerequisite for breaking the cycle of impunity. Our collective response must be resolute, unwavering and decisive. There can be no tolerance for those responsible for inflicting mass suffering upon the most vulnerable and defenceless. All perpetrators must face the most severe consequences for their crimes. In that regard, criminal accountability holds the utmost importance. However, above all, the international community must consolidate efforts to exert maximum pressure on Russia to end its brutal war of aggression, its war crimes and crimes against

humanity in Ukraine. The truth is there, the evidence is there, and the punishment shall come.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Germany.

Mr. Geisler (Germany): Germany aligns itself with the statements made on behalf of the European Union, on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect and on behalf of the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security.

Please allow me to make some additional remarks in my national capacity.

The report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/413), which was presented here today, provides an appalling picture of the global situation regarding conflict-related sexual violence. It describes a deep crisis of impunity and an unacceptable rule of lawlessness. Sexualized violence is deliberately being used as a tactic of war and as a means of torture and of political repression by States and non-State actors, such as armed groups and mercenaries. It leaves societies traumatized for decades. It is a hindrance to reconciliation and goes unpunished too often. We have to ensure accountability by effectively prosecuting perpetrators. That is why we strongly support the mandate and work of Special Representative of the Secretary-General Patten, her Team of Experts on the Rule of Law and Sexual Violence in Conflict and the United Nations Action against Sexual Violence in Conflict. We support regularly inviting Special Representative of the Secretary-General Patten to brief sanctions committees. We call on all States to join us in imposing restrictive measures against perpetrators of sexualized violence in conflict.

How can we prevent conflict-related sexual violence from happening in the first place? Wars and armed attacks must be prevented at all costs. Furthermore, we have to level power imbalances that disadvantage women economically and politically, and we have to combat misogyny and gender stereotypes, which enable gender-based violence. While the fight against the structural root causes of conflict-related sexual violence is a long-term endeavour, I would like to point out essential measures that can protect and support survivors and victims in the short term.

Recent reports suggest that there is a strong link between increased militarization and the proliferation of weapons, on the one hand, and the occurrence of sexual violence in conflict, on the other. Member States

must therefore establish effective arms and ammunition control regimes. We also need to deploy more gender advisers in peace operations and special political missions. Moreover, Member States need to provide accessible sexual and reproductive health services, and psychological and legal support and reparations. Last but not least, we have to match words with actions and provide predictable and reliable funding to combat conflict-related sexual violence.

Germany strongly supports the mandate of Special Representative of the Secretary-General Patten and the Team of Experts on the Rule of Law and Sexual Violence in Conflict. This year we contributed a project budget of €1 million for their important work. Since 2023, we have been at the lead of the Call to Action on Protection from Gender-based Violence in Emergencies, aimed at systemically improving the prevention and mitigation of gender-based violence. We will continue to be strongly engaged.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of South Africa.

Ms. Joyini (South Africa): I would like to thank you, Sir, for convening this critical debate today on this necessary yet disturbing topic. We thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Ms. Pramila Patten, and the other briefers from the field for sharing their insights with us today.

South Africa associates itself with the statement delivered by the representative of Canada on behalf of the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security.

Conflict-related sexual violence, as an occurrence, is shameful, but its continued use as weapon of war is especially heinous. It is a grave violation of international human rights law and international criminal law, and it is important that the international community take a strong stance on that. It is distressing to note that the victims and survivors of such violence are often persons who already experience systemic discrimination or persecution. In particular, women and girls are targeted for rape, gang rape and abductions, causing personal harm, social disruption and prolonged socioeconomic consequences, which extend beyond the end of direct violence. The report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/413) reminds us that people are often targeted on the basis of their sexual orientation and gender identity, and we encourage greater recognition of that reality in the resolutions of the Council.

The report of the Secretary-General highlights the strong linkage between instability, or weakened governance, and the increase in sexual violence. Poor rule of law and weakened State authority result in an increase in sexual violence, as non-State actors conduct themselves without any concern or accountability. We must seek measures to act against such atrocity crimes and crimes against humanity. That should be done through prevention, protection and the provision of support for victims and/or survivors. We therefore recognize the value of women's protection advisers in the field and encourage the continued use of that endorsed priority measure. Unfortunately, we are disheartened by the limited resources allocated for such personnel and strongly advocate for an increased allocation of resources, including through measures called for in resolution 2467 (2019).

It is important to recognize that most State actors that are listed in the report have made formal commitments to adopt measures to address conflict-related sexual violence. We must therefore work to support those State actors in their efforts. Yet it is non-State actors who are particularly prone to the use of sexual violence as a weapon, and the existence of such actors is directly connected to instability and weakened governance. We therefore continue to advocate for increased support to State actors and actions that address instability, including unconstitutional changes of Government, an issue which is also highlighted in the Secretary-General's report.

In conclusion, South Africa remains committed in its efforts to address this terrible crime. Our work and focus must seek to prevent such crimes, support victims and survivors, and hold perpetrators accountable. We encourage the continued work on this issue by the Security Council and remain committed to supporting its ongoing efforts.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Denmark.

Mr. Hermann (Denmark): I have the honour to deliver this statement on behalf of the Nordic countries — Finland, Iceland, Norway, Sweden and of course my own country, Denmark.

I want to begin by thanking our distinguished briefers, first and foremost, for their sobering statements, and not least for their vital work in this field. Sexual violence continued to be used throughout 2022 as a tactic of war, an instrument of intimidation and a

way to dehumanize and destroy communities and the lives of civilians in countries such as the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Haiti, Libya, Myanmar and South Sudan. We are deeply alarmed by the reports of persistent and deepening patterns of sexual violence by both State and non-State actors. In Ukraine, the United Nations Human Rights Monitoring Mission and the Independent International Commission of Inquiry have documented and reported sexual violence used as a form of torture and inhumane treatment of civilians and prisoners of war, violence that is overwhelmingly perpetrated by Russian military personnel.

Let us not mince words. Conflict-related sexual violence is a clear violation of international humanitarian law and international human rights law, and may constitute war crimes and crimes against humanity. And as the Secretary-General has pointed out time and again, impunity for acts of conflict-related sexual violence remains the norm. That state of affairs needs to be addressed, and it needs to change. Conflict-related sexual violence can and must be prevented and countered. It is within the power and responsibility of Member States to make that happen. It is the Council's responsibility to act. To that end, the Nordic countries would like to emphasize the following.

First, Member States must investigate all cases, prosecute perpetrators through appropriate judicial mechanisms and guarantee access to justice for victims and survivors. Secondly, our humanitarian response to conflict-related sexual violence must be gender-transformative and put survivors' needs front and centre. That can be done through cash programming, sexual and reproductive health services such as access to emergency contraception and safe and timely abortion care, and mental health and psychosocial support. Thirdly, all sanctions regimes must explicitly include sexual and gender-based violence as a designation criterion. The Security Council Sanctions Committees should list perpetrators when there is repeated evidence of conflict-related sexual violence, including as put forward annually in the annex to the Secretary-General's report. Lastly, the capacity and skills to respond to conflict-related sexual violence and to refer different types of victims to appropriate service providers must be built across peace operations — not just among women peacekeepers. The notion that women are inherently better at responding to conflict-related sexual violence or specifically responsible for doing so both perpetuates the idea that their primary added

value is related to their gender and reflects a narrow understanding of the survivors and perpetrators of conflict-related sexual violence.

Protection is the bedrock for women's full, equal and meaningful participation in political, social and economic processes, and that in turn is critical to ending conflict-related sexual violence and preventing its recurrence. We can therefore no longer watch survivors being sidelined and excluded from security policy. We, the Nordic countries, will continue to work in collaboration with all partners, including security stakeholders and institutions, civil society and women-led and feminist organizations, not least at the local level, to push back on any attempt to hinder the full, equal and meaningful participation of all women. Let me conclude by underlining that we continue to stand firm on zero tolerance for any reprisals against women human rights defenders and fully support their advocacy for gender equality and the defence of human rights.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Italy.

Mr. Massari (Italy): I would like to thank the United Kingdom for organizing this annual open debate, as well as Ms. Pramila Patten, the Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict, and the civil-society representatives for their briefings.

Italy aligns itself with the statements delivered on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security, as well as the statement to be delivered by the representative of Botswana on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect, and would like to add the following remarks in its national capacity.

This year we celebrate the fifteenth anniversary of the adoption of resolution 1820 (2008), which established conflict-related sexual violence as a stand-alone security issue. Since then, the United Nations has developed a more robust normative framework to address the issue, in particular by establishing the mandate of the Special Representative. We reiterate our strong support for the mandate and work of the Office of the Special Representative and the Team of Experts on the Rule of Law and Sexual Violence in Conflict. Yet we are facing a disturbing reality in which conflicts are increasing in frequency, scope and intensity. Sexual violence, slavery and exploitation are also proliferating in the context of internal and cross-border displacement, protracted displacement, abduction and

trafficking. Respect for international humanitarian law and international human rights law is being challenged to an unprecedented extent.

We are deeply concerned about the blurring of the distinction between the respective responsibilities of State and non-State actors, highlighted in the Secretary-General's report (S/2023/413), which complicates the attribution of the heinous crimes that are being committed and undermines accountability. We condemn the use of sexual violence as a deliberate tactic of warfare, and we join the call of the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security urging the Security Council to use all the tools at its disposal to support effective action against conflict-related sexual and gender-based violence as a weapon of war. We also recognize the important role of the International Criminal Court in investigating and prosecuting sexual violence in the context of armed conflicts, in accordance with its mandate under the Rome Statute and the relevant Security Council resolutions.

As the Secretary-General writes in his report, "harnessing the preventive power of the rule of law is essential", and it is indeed time to take action. All the risk factors that contribute to making sexual violence in conflict a largely underreported crime must be addressed in a comprehensive way if we want to actually break the cycle of impunity. On the one hand, we must act on prevention, to disrupt the gender inequality entrenched in harmful social norms and practices; on the other, we must act on response, to remove the multiple barriers that hinder access to services, reporting and formal justice. We must invest in programmes and policies aimed at ensuring that assistance is accessible and safe for victims and survivors, free from the fear of social stigma, intimidation and reprisal. We must invest in gender-responsive security and justice sector reforms. We must ensure that those same principles are embedded in the training of military personnel deployed at the national level, as well as in United Nations peacekeeping and special political missions.

The women and peace and security agenda provides a crucial framework for the collective action of the Council. We commend the work of women's civil-society organizations, which are often at the front line in wars and conflicts, providing relief and protection and contributing to building and consolidating community resilience. We reiterate the importance of supporting safe spaces for women's effective participation in the framework of credible and sustainable national action

plans on women and peace and security. In that context, we call on the international community to reaffirm the commitment to addressing the root causes of conflict and the structural gender inequalities and barriers hindering the full enjoyment of rights by all women and girls in all areas of public and political life.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Chile.

Mr. Ruidíaz Pérez (Chile) (*spoke in Spanish*): Chile thanks the United Kingdom for convening today's open debate. We have taken note of the presentations and contributions we have heard.

Chile aligns itself with the statement made on behalf of the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security and to be made on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect.

Chile condemns sexual violence in armed conflict. Such sexual and gender-based violence, used systematically and repeatedly as a tactic of war, is a grave violation of human rights and constitutes a war crime. The Security Council has rightly recognized that sexual violence can significantly exacerbate and prolong situations of armed conflict and hinder the restoration of peace. These behaviours cannot be trivialized, nor can they be assumed to be a collateral cost of war or internal crisis situations.

For this and many other reasons, we believe that it is essential that the gender perspective be permanently integrated or deepened in the training of the armed forces, including measures to prevent sexual violence and, this should be extended to contingents participating in peacekeeping missions. Accordingly, Chile supports the Secretary-General's Action for Peacekeeping initiative, which requires appropriate conduct by all personnel of the Organization in missions and supports the United Nations zero-tolerance policy, which includes a victim-centred approach to all forms of sexual exploitation and abuse.

Chile is concerned that there are still many situations of sexual violence in armed conflicts that have not been investigated or prosecuted, which could have a deterrent and preventive effect. It is therefore incumbent upon the international community to react and support countries in strengthening their justice institutions, always bearing in mind the possibility of resorting to international tribunals, such as the International Criminal Court, when appropriate.

Accordingly, Chile reiterates its commitment to international instruments that punish acts of sexual violence as war crimes, such as the Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court and the Geneva Conventions that form the core of international humanitarian law. Likewise, compliance with the resolutions of the Security Council is imperative if we are to put an end to the use of sexual violence as a weapon of war. Resolution 1820 (2008) was an important step in recognizing this violence, and subsequent resolutions demonstrate that the issue is an ongoing concern of the Council. Resolution 1960 (2010) also establishes a system of accountability to put an end to sexual violence associated with conflict situations, which has worsened in recent years.

In the same vein, Chile supports the designation of targeted sanctions, applied by relevant Security Council committees, against those involved in the commission of crimes of sexual violence, either as perpetrators or as ideologues. It is also important to provide multidisciplinary, timely and non-discriminatory assistance so as to enable victims to be fully reintegrated into their communities and contribute to peacebuilding. This is essential to promoting, protecting and guaranteeing access for victims of sexual violence to adequate health services that allow for the rehabilitation of survivors.

Finally, there must be a commitment by the entire international community to support the efforts of post-conflict countries to incorporate the issue of sexual violence in armed conflict as a specific issue in transitional justice, promoting legal mechanisms to receive complaints and carry out criminal investigations.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Uruguay.

Mr. Amorín (Uruguay) (*spoke in Spanish*): First of all, I would like to thank the United Kingdom's presidency of the Security Council this month for convening today's open debate on the particularly relevant issue of conflict-related sexual violence and linking it to the promotion of Security Council resolutions on the subject. I am also grateful for the presence of Ms. Pramila Patten, Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict, who spoke this morning, as well as the representatives of civil society who also spoke on the subject this morning.

Sexual violence in armed conflict is brutal, deliberate and intended to punish and/or humiliate individuals and their communities. It is often motivated by political, military and economic objectives, and it is used to control territory and resources. It is often perpetrated in the context of abuses against civilian populations that are likely to be targeted because of their perceived or actual membership in an ethnic group, a religious minority or a political group or because of their actual or perceived gender identity or sexual orientation.

The Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court includes rape and certain other types of sexual violence in its list of war crimes and in the list of acts constituting crimes against humanity when committed as part of a widespread or systematic attack against the civilian population. Resolution 1820 (2008), unanimously adopted by the Security Council, recognizes that sexual violence can form the basis of such international crimes as crimes against humanity or torture or even be a constitutive act of genocide. Through various resolutions, including resolution 2467 (2019), the Security Council has repeatedly reiterated its concern about ongoing acts of violence against women and children in conflict situations.

Despite the existence of a comprehensive normative legal framework on sexual and gender-based violence, the report submitted by the Secretary-General on conflict-related sexual violence (S/2023/413) continues to report on a variety of situations, including in Afghanistan, the Central African Republic, Colombia, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Iraq, Libya, Mali, Myanmar, Somalia, the Sudan, South Sudan, Syria, Ukraine and Yemen. In his recommendations to the Security Council, the Secretary-General calls on all parties to conflicts to put an end to all forms of conflict-related sexual violence.

Uruguay understands that this recommendation is fundamental, but also insufficient if the recommendations set forth in sub-paragraphs (e) and (f) of paragraph 90 of the Secretary General's report, on consultations in the field, especially with free women-led organizations, and early warning, respectively, are not also followed. In this context, it is first essential to ensure that sexual violence is systematically monitored and incorporated as a separate designation criterion for the imposition of targeted sanctions, in order to deter all parties, including mercenaries and private military and security companies, from committing

such violence (sub-paragraph 90 (g)). We believe that the pressing seriousness of this issue must be addressed with appropriate incentives to combat it.

Secondly, we echo the recommendation contained in paragraph 90 (h) of the report to consider the possibility that the Council refer to the Office of the Prosecutor of the International Criminal Court situations in which crimes of sexual violence, as defined in the Rome Statute, appear to have been committed. The certainty that there will be accountability for these crimes — which are, as I mentioned earlier, brutal and deliberate — must be increasingly present if they are to be fought with strength.

The President: I would remind all speakers to limit their statements to no more than three minutes.

I now give the floor to the representative of Botswana.

Mr. Dabutha (Botswana): I have the honour of delivering this statement on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect, consisting of 55 member States and the European Union, and this year co-chaired by Botswana, Costa Rica and Croatia. The Group would like to thank the United Kingdom for organizing today's important open debate and the briefers for their insightful remarks.

This year marks the fifteenth anniversary of the adoption of resolution 1820 (2008). Despite the progress made to implement this important resolution, sexual violence remains pervasive in conflicts today, affecting thousands of persons every year, in particular women and children.

The 2022 annual report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/413) identifies 17 countries in which conflict-related sexual violence is being perpetrated. We can only assume this is the tip of the iceberg, as sexual violence remains severely underreported. It is therefore urgent that we devise strategies to collectively address and prevent conflict-related sexual violence and uphold our own responsibility to protect, and we must reject the perception that sexual and gender-based violence is an inevitable product of war.

As it is the primary responsibility of Member States to protect their populations against atrocity crimes, including those involving rape and other forms of sexual violence, the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect would like to stress the following points.

First, strengthening the capacity of national institutions is critical to ensuring accountability and to preventing and deterring such crimes in future. The connection between conflict-related sexual violence and gender-based violence and discrimination against women and girls in times of peace is very clear. In this regard, it is of utmost importance that States put in place and enforce legislative and institutional processes to comprehensively address all forms of sexual and gender-based violence in peace time as well as during conflict. Ensuring that States are aware of their obligations and responsibilities to address conflict-related sexual violence under international law is essential if we are to close the implementation gap.

Secondly, where national institutions are not able or willing to take action against perpetrators of sexual violence, the international community should act to ensure accountability for such crimes. For example, the Security Council has shown that it can use targeted sanctions against those who perpetrate and direct sexual violence in armed conflict and we encourage it to take further such action.

Thirdly, there is an urgent need for survivor-centred and trauma-informed approaches to support the needs of victims and survivors of sexual and gender-based violence during and after situations of conflict, including the needs of children born from sexual violence in conflict.

Lastly, at the heart of sexual and gender-based violence lies a disregard for human rights, as well as the perpetuation of systematic gender inequality, asymmetric power structures and pervasive discrimination.

Sexual violence in conflict must be addressed with the full, equal and meaningful and leadership of women, including women's rights and civil society organizations, in the establishment of prevention mechanisms. That also requires the inclusion of survivors and affected communities in identifying holistic solutions that address their needs. It is equally important to continue to engage men and community leaders to play a positive role in combating sexual violence and addressing gender stereotypes and the exclusion of women and girls.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of the Dominican Republic.

Mrs. Cedano (Dominican Republic) (*spoke in Spanish*): I would like to express my deep gratitude to the United Kingdom for convening this important debate. I would also like to recognize the leadership and work of Ms. Pramila Patten and her Office, as well as express my gratitude to the other briefers for their valuable contributions. I thank them for shedding light on the harsh realities of conflict-related sexual violence.

With 2,455 cases verified by the United Nations and many other cases that remain hidden, it is clear that sexual violence remains a perverse and devastating scourge in conflict. Ninety-four per cent of the victims are women and girls, and the vast majority are girls. It is a bleak perspective that has worsened in several conflict scenarios. It is used as a tactic of terror, torture, intimidation and political repression, and a ruthless tool of forced displacement and the dehumanization of innocent and vulnerable people. The consequences of that violence are deep and long-lasting for the victims. They suffer not only physically and psychologically, but also socially. They are often stigmatized, isolated and weighed down by deep and heartbreaking trauma.

In the face of this urgent situation, we must confront conflict-related sexual violence with unwavering determination and collective action. It is necessary to adopt a comprehensive approach that encompasses prevention, protection, justice, support for survivors and strong legal frameworks that criminalize such acts and ensure accountability for perpetrators. Accountability must be the fundamental pillar in our fight against conflict-related sexual violence, thereby bringing an end to impunity. At the same time, it is critical to focus on the needs and rights of women and girls and to tirelessly persevere in the struggle for gender equality and the full respect for and enjoyment of their human rights. International law establishes the obligations of States and parties to conflict to prevent, investigate and sanction such heinous acts. In that regard, it is vital that the Council's resolutions that address that issue be fully implemented to ensure accountability and serve justice for the victims.

Let me underscore the worrisome situation in Haiti. The report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/413) confirms alarming levels of conflict-related sexual violence in that country. Criminal gangs have used the violence as a weapon of war to punish and terrorize entire communities. The adoption of resolution 2653 (2022), which creates a Sanctions Committee and a Panel of Experts, has been an important step to monitor

and address that unfortunate situation, and we hope that the upcoming report of the Secretary-General will provide us with more encouraging data following the efforts made by the Haitian authorities and the commitment of the parties to fulfil their obligations.

I must emphasize that the renewal of the mandate of the United Nations Integrated Office in Haiti (BINUH) through resolution 2692 (2023) today was another important step. That resolution establishes that BINUH's human rights unit will include dedicated capacity to address sexual and gender-based violence, including the identification of women's protection advisers.

The situation in Haiti also reminds us how crucial it is to work towards the elimination of illicit trafficking in weapons and ammunition in combating violence against women and girls.

Empowering local communities and engaging men and boys as partners in this struggle is critical to achieve inclusive and sustainable change. Bringing an end to this horrendous crime is up to all of us, together with our collective responsibility to restore the dignity of all victims and survivors.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Luxembourg.

Mr. Maes (Luxembourg) (*spoke in French*): I would like to thank the United Kingdom for organizing this open debate as part of its presidency. We also extend our thanks to Special Representative Pramila Patten and her team and to the two representatives of civil society for their recommendations.

Luxembourg fully endorses the statements delivered on behalf of the European Union and on behalf of the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security and the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect. Allow me to add a few considerations in my national capacity.

The fundamental human rights of survivors, such as the rights to dignity, privacy, health, safety, access to justice, truth and an effective remedy, are at the heart of Luxembourg's feminist foreign policy. In that context, my country has just signed the Murad Code and joined the new International Alliance on Preventing Sexual Violence in Conflict. We are grateful to the United Kingdom for launching those initiatives and encourage all Member States to join them.

Luxembourg also continues to support the Stand Speak Rise Up! initiative, the United Nations Population Fund, UN-Women and Justice Rapid Response, as well as the mandate of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict.

Despite the numerous resolutions adopted by the Security Council since 2008, sexual violence persists and continues to be used as a weapon of war in Mali, Myanmar, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, the Sudan, South Sudan, Syria and other conflicts. As the Secretary-General points out in his report (S/2023/413), the number of actors involved is multiplying.

In Ukraine, the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights documented 109 cases of sexual violence perpetrated by the Russian military. Victims ranged in age from 4 to 82 years old. In that regard too, we can speak of the use of sexual violence as a weapon of war.

In order to put an end to the cycles of sexual violence, Luxembourg wishes to make four recommendations.

First, the fight against impunity must be at the centre of our efforts. The International Criminal Court has a key role to play. Sexual violence in conflict is a war crime and may constitute a crime against humanity or genocide. We support the work under way on a convention on crimes against humanity.

Secondly, through investigative mechanisms, we must support the documentation of the crimes committed.

Thirdly, close cooperation with civil society must be ensured, and we must protect those key partners from reprisals by taking appropriate measures.

Fourthly and finally, we must tackle the root causes of sexual violence and redouble our prevention efforts. It is a matter not only of putting an end to the culture of impunity, but also of recognizing that sexual violence is linked to gender inequality.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Belgium.

Mr. Cardon De Lichtbuer (Belgium): Belgium aligns itself with the statements made on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security.

We would like to thank the United Kingdom for organizing this important debate and Special Representative of the Secretary-General Patten for

her remarks, and we explicitly thank the civil society briefers for their powerful and insightful contributions. Participation by civil society allows us to take into consideration the experiences of those affected. Everything we say and do should fully take into account the needs and perspectives of the survivors of this abhorrent crime. By doing so, it is clear that access to justice, as well as sexual and reproductive health, rights and services, should be an integral part of United Nations and national responses to conflict-related sexual violence. For survivors of conflict-related sexual violence this means, *inter alia*, access to treatment for internal physical injuries, sexually transmitted diseases, emergency contraception, safe abortion and pre- and post-natal care.

(spoke in French)

Today's presentations and the Secretary-General's report (S/2023/413) are quite disconcerting, particularly with regard to the extremely low levels of compliance, including by States. There is an urgent need to bridge that gap. Implementation also means enforcement and the fight against impunity. My Government is supporting that effort, *inter alia*, by funding the Team of Experts on the Rule of Law and Sexual Violence in Conflict, which is cooperating with the authorities of Ukraine and the Democratic Republic of the Congo, among others. We welcome their commitment, encourage them and others to continue on that path and call on other States to consider supporting the Team of Experts.

(spoke in English)

Moreover, while acknowledging that preventing and addressing conflict-related sexual violence is the primary responsibility of States, Belgium stresses the need to explore how conflict-related sexual violence can be connected to sanctions policy and practices, for instance, by considering a more systematic input of information from the Office of the Special Representative to the Council's sanctions committees.

Finally, we should recognize that conflict-related sexual violence is rooted in structural gender inequality and harmful social norms. Belgium could not agree more with the Secretary-General's recommendations to tackle the root causes of conflict-related sexual violence by promoting women's and girls' leadership, by creating an enabling environment for women and girls active in public life and by stepping up to protect women politicians from violence and reprisals.

Mr. Liepnieks (Latvia): On behalf of the Baltic countries — Estonia, Lithuania, and my own country, Latvia — I extend my gratitude to the United Kingdom for organizing this open debate and to the distinguished briefers for their presentations.

As we reflect upon the previous year, we see that sexual violence persisted as a cruel weapon of war, torture and terrorism in various regions, including in Myanmar, Syria, Libya and Iran, where it was employed to intimidate and punish political opponents. Displaced women and girls in Mozambique, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Somalia and the Sudan fell victim to sexual assault by armed individuals in and around displacement sites.

The Baltic States commend the tireless efforts of the United Nations in addressing those horrific situations. We appreciate the work of the United Nations Action against Sexual Violence in Conflict inter-agency network for their initiatives providing crucial support to survivors, including medical, psychological, legal and socioeconomic assistance. A notable example is the project implemented in the conflict-free mining sites in the Democratic Republic of the Congo. We also express our appreciation to the Team of Experts on the Rule of Law and Sexual Violence in Conflict for their contributions to strengthening rule of law institutions. Their efforts, including assisting Guinean authorities in establishing an *ad hoc* tribunal, deserve recognition.

Unfortunately, conflict-related sexual violence is also part of the full-scale war of aggression waged by the Russian Federation against Ukraine. Since 24 February 2022, the United Nations human rights monitoring mission in Ukraine documented 125 cases of conflict-related sexual violence affecting civilians and prisoners of war, while the real number is even higher. The heinous acts committed by the Russian armed forces and groups as a tactic of war included torture methods such as electrocution, beatings, burns, forced nudity and rape, including gang rape. The victims ranged from young children to the elderly, with perpetrators even raping women and girls in front of their family members. Moreover, Russia's attacks on hospitals hindered access to services for managing the aftermath of sexual violence. It is horrendous that a permanent member of this esteemed Council is responsible for these crimes and continues to commit atrocities on a daily basis. Furthermore, the Russian Federation seeks to stifle the voice and actions of the United Nations through its veto powers.

Yet, the international community refuses to be silenced. The General Assembly recognized the need to hold the Russian Federation accountable and to establish an international mechanism for reparations. In May, a register of damage was established under the Council of Europe, signifying steps towards justice for Ukraine. We look forward to the meeting of Ministers of Justice of the Council of Europe to be held in Riga in September to continue implementing the register of damage.

In conclusion, we express our appreciation for the Special Representative's tireless work. We pledge our unwavering support to her and to anyone dedicated to preventing sexual violence, assisting survivors and ensuring accountability for the perpetrators, both in Ukraine and elsewhere.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Romania.

Ms. Mocanu (Romania): Thank you, Mr. President, for convening today's open debate. I also thank the briefers, Special Representative of the Secretary-General Ms. Patten and the representatives of civil society for sharing the realities of sexual violence in conflicts.

My delegation aligns itself with the statement of the European Union and also the statements delivered on behalf of the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security and the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect.

Allow me to share some national perspectives. Seventy-five years since the establishment of the United Nations, the adoption of its Charter and of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, one thing remains clear: a world without human rights is a world without peace. This year's report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/413) identified 17 countries in which conflict-related sexual violence is deployed as a strategy in conflict by terrorist and non-State armed groups, but also by State authorities. Unfortunately, in almost all settings covered in the report, impunity persists, undermining peace processes and reconstruction efforts.

Our national pledge to implement the provisions of the Security Council resolutions on combating abuse and sexual exploitation in conflict are mostly visible in two areas. On the one hand, we have invested in training our armed forces, including those participating in peacekeeping activities, on the prohibition of all

forms of sexual violence against civilians. On the other hand, the active presence of Romania as co-chair of the Women and Peace and Security Focal Points Network, reconfirms our commitment to advancing the global women and peace and security agenda, which also includes conflict-related sexual violence. We will make sure that the topic will be diligently addressed at the ministerial meeting of the Women and Peace and Security Focal Points Network to be held in September.

The Secretary-General's report raises awareness regarding the increased risks of trafficking for the purposes of sexual exploitation in Ukraine's vicinity following the large-scale displacements triggered by the war of aggression started by Russia. Allow me to assure you that the Romanian authorities, along with partners from civil society and the private sector, worked tirelessly to circumvent that phenomenon. Among the measures put in place by Romania to prevent the risks associated with human trafficking for refugees from Ukraine, I would like to mention a mechanism for the early identification of victims, the establishment of a national emergency fund for victims, a dedicated working group for preventing sexual exploitation and the funding of non-governmental organizations for delivering survivor-centred support, including access to psychosocial, health care and legal services.

We invested all those efforts because we consider that ending the climate of impunity is the way forward to prevent and respond to conflict-related sexual violence. Likewise, we believe that accountability measures should be adopted and implemented at the national level and international accountability mechanisms should be in place. The stories of survivors of sexual violence, mostly women and girls, like the ones we heard this morning, need to be told, but most importantly, need to be heard so that action can follow. As government representatives, we need to create the conditions to ensure that conflict-related sexual violence does not remain underreported or continue to be one of the least condemned crimes.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Spain.

Mr. Gutiérrez Segú Berdullas (Spain) (*spoke in Spanish*): Spain aligns itself with the statements made on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security, of which it is a member.

The Security Council has recognized that the best way to protect civilians, and in particular women and girls, from sexual violence in conflict is through prevention and deterrence, so that sexual violence ceases to be used as a weapon of war. In addition, it has established punitive measures against perpetrators and reparations for survivors, which should guarantee the prevention of impunity. However, we find that impunity is the general and usual rule where accountability is concerned. Impunity prevails when cases against perpetrators fail in the first instance, or when there is resort to extrajudicial solutions that are far removed from international standards of justice and reparations for victims.

Spain understands that the best way to strengthen the prevention of sexual violence is to work for gender equality, the promotion and protection of human rights and the full, meaningful and effective participation of women in their societies. Moreover, prevention works best when women themselves and their organizations are involved in the effort, and when they are provided with the necessary resources to carry out that work. Therefore, we must commit to predictable and sustained funding for the multi-stakeholder trust fund.

Another effective way to combat impunity in practice is to urgently deploy personnel with expertise in sexual violence in conflict and gender-based violence to investigate cases and create safe environments in transit and destination countries. The generation of evidence is key to continued efforts in that area. Similarly, it is essential for peace operations to improve and expand protection mandates. It is important that the response to that violence focus on survivors and victims, with a comprehensive approach that covers access to health-care services, including sexual and reproductive, mental and psychosocial health, legal support and livelihood and/or income-generating projects. In that regard, we welcome the fact that the United Nations Action against Sexual Violence in Conflict adopts such an approach.

Spain's third national action plan on women and peace and security will pay special attention to women in Ukraine. It will include measures to ensure the investigation of the use of sexual violence as a weapon of war and the protection of victims, as well as the meaningful participation of women in peacebuilding and reconstruction in Ukraine. Spain, together with the Netherlands, organizes the course on a comprehensive approach to gender in operations, which is taught four times a year and has as one of its objectives to equip both

military and civilian personnel with practical means to interact with local women and men. In addition, Spain will organize in the coming months a series of meetings on the fight against sexual violence in conflict, within the framework of our presidency of the Council of the European Union.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Portugal.

Ms. Zacarias (Portugal): Portugal aligns with the statements delivered on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security and categorically condemns the use of sexual and gender-based violence by State and non-State actors in situations of humanitarian crises and conflict-affected settings.

We welcome the convening of this debate, which is particularly significant in the light of the concerning trends emphasized in the Secretary-General's report (S/2023/413). The widespread pattern of sexual violence it depicts shows how pressing is the work and mandate of Special Representative Ms. Pramila Patten, whom I thank for her briefing.

One of the alarming trends highlighted in the report is the use of sexual violence as a tactic of war by non-State armed groups to consolidate control over territories or exploit lucrative natural resources in certain countries. Furthermore, the increasing proliferation of mercenary groups has also led to a rise in violations and abuses of human rights and violations of international humanitarian law. Conflict-related sexual violence continues to cause massive displacement, both internally and across borders. The refugee crisis stemming from the war in Ukraine has led to a rampant risk of trafficking of women for sexual exploitation. In that regard, we welcome the establishment of a comprehensive inter-agency working group to address sexual violence, with a focus on anti-trafficking measures.

As armed conflicts escalate and their devastating consequences unfold, disproportionately affecting women and children, we cannot remain idle. Those abhorrent crimes must be punished and the perpetrators brought to justice. The Security Council has already adopted a comprehensive framework to prevent and address conflict-related sexual violence. We call on all States to ensure its implementation in national legislation and make clear efforts to combat sexual and gender-based violence, safeguard women's rights

during times of conflict, provide redress for survivors and ensure accountability for perpetrators.

But combating conflict-related sexual violence is also a shared responsibility that rests with all of us gathered here today. The Security Council can make significant advances by designating conflict-related sexual violence as a criterion in all relevant United Nations sanctions regimes. The United Nations and Member States can also bolster accountability efforts and increase compliance with international legal frameworks by assisting other Member States to harmonize domestic laws with international standards and providing support to justice systems, both military and civilian. In order for that to happen, States must cooperate with those efforts at every level, embracing a genuine desire to promote equality between women and men in the realization of civil, cultural, economic, political and social rights; dismantling discriminatory social norms and gender stereotypes and working on prevention. That is the only way to ensure the end of sexual and gender-based violence, in any setting, while also fostering sustainable peace and political and social stability, which should be the main driver of all our actions.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of the Kingdom of the Netherlands.

Ms. Brandt (Kingdom of the Netherlands): The Kingdom of the Netherlands aligns itself with the statements made on behalf of the European Union, the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security and the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect.

Let me thank you, Mr. President, and the United Kingdom for organizing today's debate and for keeping conflict-related sexual violence on the Council's agenda. We would also like to thank Special Representative of the Secretary-General Patten for her briefing this morning and reiterate our full support for her mandate. We are very grateful for the important work the Special Representative of the Secretary-General and her staff are doing, despite difficult circumstances. Allow me to also extend my special gratitude to today's civil society briefers. We would like to thank them for their courage to break the circle of silence and stigma around conflict-related sexual violence. Their experiences and contributions — as well as those of other civil society organizations and survivors — should guide our efforts to prevent and address conflict-related sexual violence.

As we heard from the presentations and the debate today, levels of sexual violence are increasing. Horrific reports, including from the Sudan and Ukraine, have illustrated its severe and lasting impacts on individuals, communities and societies, and sadly, the numbers in the report on conflict-related sexual violence are only the tip of the iceberg. We urgently need more and better data in order to fully capture the scale of this problem and to better tailor our responses. Urgent and joined-up efforts are needed to improve the availability and harmonization of data across the system, while, of course, ensuring safety and confidentiality.

I would briefly like to mention three areas for action today.

First, we need to eliminate harmful social norms and gender stereotypes that perpetuate or justify conflict-related sexual violence and address its root causes. Such action is something that cannot be taken overnight, but good practices already exist. For example, in South Sudan, the Netherlands supports a project that promotes discussions on positive masculinity, and works with religious and local leaders to adequately address gender-based violence. We should look at sharing and scaling up those best practices.

Secondly, as also mentioned by Ms. Naw Hser Hser this morning, we need to protect those in the most vulnerable positions, including women human rights defenders. The year 2023 marks 25 years since the adoption of the United Nations Declaration on Human Rights Defenders, so we should feel a special responsibility to support those courageous women and be clear that any form of violence or intimidation, or any attempt to limit their space to speak up, is unacceptable.

Finally, it is important to adopt a holistic approach to national and international accountability. Justice should not be seen as limited to criminal proceedings. We should respect the choices of victims and survivors when it comes to their path to healing, recovering and finding justice, and make sure that their choices inform our policies and programmes. And a final point on accountability: When States are unwilling or unable to act, thematic sanctions can serve as a last resort, as shown by the initiative of the Netherlands, in collaboration with Germany and France, for European Union sanctions for acts of violence against women.

With our feminist foreign policy, the Kingdom of the Netherlands stands firmly for the right to a dignified life free from violence for all. We are committed to work

with all stakeholders for concrete action and progress, to take preventative action and to better the lives of those affected by conflict-related sexual violence.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of the Republic of Korea.

Mr. Hwang (Republic of Korea): My delegation would like to express its appreciation to the United Kingdom for convening today's open debate on this important matter. We would also like to convey our gratitude to all the briefers, including the Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict, Ms. Pramila Patten, and warmly welcome this year's report by the Secretary-General (S/2023/413).

The Republic of Korea aligns itself with the statement delivered by the representative of Canada on behalf of the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security and the statement to be delivered by the representative of Botswana on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect. I would now like to deliver the following statement in our national capacity.

Since the unanimously adopted resolution 1820 (2008) in 2008, on conflict-related sexual violence, the Council has renewed and strengthened its commitment to eliminating conflict-related sexual violence through several related resolutions in the years that followed. The key promise that those resolutions made was to prevent and eradicate such crimes. Nevertheless, it is distressing to note that the latest report of the Secretary-General documents over 2,000 cases of conflict-related sexual violence again, including in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, South Sudan and Ukraine, with little significant reduction observed over the past decade.

In particular, the Republic of Korea is deeply concerned about pervasive impunity for conflict-related sexual violence, which not only discourages the victims from reporting the crimes but also instils fear of reprisals or the recurrence of violence. Impunity must not become the norm, and conflict-related sexual violence should not be seen as an inevitable consequence of conflict. While ensuring accountability at both the local and national levels is crucial, my delegation also supports the Security Council's efforts to incorporate sexual and gender-based violence as a designation criterion for United Nations sanctions regimes. Targeted United Nations sanctions against those who

perpetrate and direct sexual violence in conflict can address impunity as well as serve as a deterrent.

The Republic of Korea would also like to emphasize the importance of a survivor-centred approach in addressing conflict-related sexual violence, as outlined in resolution 2467 (2019). Heeding the voices of survivors and responding to their needs are essential to provide relevant support and help them reintegrate into communities. In that regard, the Republic of Korea takes pride in its continued contributions to the Global Survivors Fund since its inception. As one of the main donors to the Fund, we have promoted its activities around the globe, which include providing survivors with financial compensation, vocational training and medical and psychological care.

Last but not least, it is critical that survivors not remain mere victims of the violence but are transformed into agents of peace. To that end, we need to make our utmost effort to ensure the full, equal, meaningful and safe participation of women at all stages of the peace process. The Republic of Korea created an international forum called Action with Women and Peace in 2018. At the fifth conference, to be held later this year, we look forward to hearing from more women, including survivors.

As an elected member of the Security Council for the term 2024—25, the Republic of Korea looks forward to contributing to the Council's noble work of preventing conflict-related sexual violence and ensuring justice for all those affected.

The President: We still have 20 speakers left, so I encourage participants to limit their statements to three minutes.

I now give the floor to the representative of Slovakia.

Mr. Chatrnúch (Slovakia): My delegation aligns itself with the statements made on behalf of the European Union and of the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect and wishes to add some remarks in its national capacity.

We would like to start by thanking the United Kingdom for organizing this important debate on women and peace and security, with a focus on conflict-related sexual violence. We would also like to thank Special Representative of the Secretary-General Patten and the representatives of civil society for their briefings.

We seize this opportunity to express our deep concern that, despite the systematic advancement of the women and peace and security agenda, the heinous practice of sexual violence in conflict is still present and widespread. This was marked by the Secretary-General in his latest report (S/2023/413). We fully agree with the Secretary-General that enhanced investment by the international community to break the vicious cycle of sexual violence and impunity is urgently needed. Special Representative of the Secretary-General Patten also recently clearly stated that

“despite increased international awareness, the global trendlines of conflict-related sexual violence are worsening”.

We consider it crucial to foster an enabling environment for victims and survivors and to provide them with accessible and quality multisectoral assistance. This includes all 17 conflict-affected countries, as described in the report, including Afghanistan, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Myanmar, Syria and the Sudan.

As the co-Chair of the Group of Friends of Security Sector Reform, Slovakia wishes to recall Security Council 2151 (2014) on security sector reform, which underscored the importance of women's equal, meaningful and effective participation and full involvement in the security sector in order to build inclusive, accountable and legitimate institutions that more effectively protect populations and promote lasting peace and sustainable development. Gender-responsive security sector reform is key to developing security sector institutions that are non-discriminatory, representative and capable of effectively responding to the specific security needs of diverse groups. It is critical to ensure that gender equality and women's empowerment are not side-lined and that funding for the women and peace and security agenda is carefully allocated. I wish to underline that the Security Council mandates should explicitly recognize women's contribution to security sector reform process and more clearly encourage peace operations to support women's meaningful participation and leadership in all stages of security sector reform processes.

One of the questions that emerged from the concept note (S/2023/476, annex) for today's open debate is how the Security Council responds to States that fail to hold perpetrators to account. This is a highly relevant query, as one permanent member of the Security Council has blatantly violated international law and the principles

of the Charter of the United Nations. The situation of many Ukrainian citizens has turned into a living hell since the Russian Federation decided to start its senseless war of choice. The ongoing, unjustified and unprovoked Russian aggression against Ukraine has resulted in serious violations of international human rights and humanitarian law, including sexual violence. That is not only a despicable act but can also qualify as a war crime or crime against humanity. We want to stress once again that all perpetrators must be brought to justice and held accountable for the crimes they have committed.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Pakistan.

Mr. Akram (Pakistan): At the outset, I would like to thank the United Kingdom presidency and in particular Lord Ahmad, the Prime Minister's Special Representative for Preventing Sexual Violence in Conflict, for convening this open debate on such a vital aspect of international peace and security. We thank Special Representative Patten and the other briefers for the information they have provided today.

Despite the Security Council's efforts since the adoption of resolution 1820 (2008), there seems to be no end in sight for the growing number of victims of conflict-related sexual violence. The Secretary-General's report (S/2023/413) has documented 2,455 cases of conflict-related sexual violence in 2022, and those represent only a small proportion of that underreported crime. The report lists 49 parties, including State and non-State actors, responsible for such crimes. However, the report's credibility is seriously undermined by what looks like a deliberate decision not to report the crimes of sexual violence being committed in Indian-occupied Jammu and Kashmir and in Israeli-occupied Palestine. There is ample documented evidence that Indian occupation forces have used rape and sexual violence as a weapon of war in occupied Kashmir since 1989. Thousands of women and girls have been raped, gang-raped or subjected to enforced incarceration, torture and abduction. The infamous Kunan Poshpora incident is raw in the memories of all Kashmiris.

Thousands of women, girls, boys and men have been detained and subjected to sexual violence and torture as punishment and humiliation. Entire communities, women, girls and boys, have been prevented from enjoying their rights, including the right to freedom of expression and religion and to

education and employment. That is corroborated by the two reports of 2018 and 2019 issued by the Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights and by international media and human rights organizations. Since India's unilateral and illegal measures of 5 August 2019, conflict-related violence and the harassment and humiliation of women and girls in Kashmir have increased significantly. We would therefore urge the Secretary-General to rectify the report's omissions, include information on the incidence of sexual violence in foreign-occupied Kashmir and Palestine and list India and Israel among the parties perpetrating conflict-related sexual violence in future reports to the Security Council.

This open debate is a sombre reminder of the need to take decisive action. We would urge that all Council resolutions related to protracted conflicts be faithfully implemented. The implementation of efforts to deal with the issue should cover all four pillars of the women and peace and security agenda, and the gaps in oversight and investigation mechanisms should be addressed to end the culture of impunity. Finally, the provision of timely assistance, health services, rehabilitation and reintegration in response to sexual violence in conflicts should be strengthened and adequately funded.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Lebanon.

Ms. Zoghbi (Lebanon): At the outset, we would like to thank the United Kingdom for organizing this important debate. We also thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict, Ms. Pramila Patten, and the other briefers for their statements earlier today. We still remember Special Representative Patten's words during last year's debate on ending cycles of sexual violence in conflict, when she stated that "[w]omen's rights are not Western rights. They are human rights" (*S/PV.9016*, p.6). Lebanon, a country that played a role in the drafting of the Universal Declaration on Human Rights — the seventy-fifth anniversary of which we are celebrating this year — strongly concurs with her.

The latest report of the Secretary-General on conflict-related sexual violence (*S/2023/413*) states that impunity remains the norm. We must ask ourselves how many times we are going to keep saying that. Survivor and Nobel Peace Prize laureate Nadia Murad's words can bring some key answers to our questions.

"Sometimes I feel as if I am repeating myself over and over again, but the messages remain important. I will keep saying them until we solve the issues".

The devastating use of sexual violence as a weapon of war — a humiliating and degrading one — continues unabated, with women and girls the main victims, although we are not forgetting that men and boys can also be targets of sexual violence in conflict. Human beings' bodies are not and should never be considered a tool of combat. In that regard, we commend the United Kingdom's leadership in preventing sexual violence in conflict. Lebanon participated in the International Preventing Sexual Violence in Conflict Initiative Conference in London in November of last year, and also endorsed the political declaration on conflict-related sexual violence.

One of the most powerful pieces at the Metropolitan Museum of Art here in New York is the early eighteenth-century French sculptor Philippe Bertrand's statue of Lucretia, which portrays Lucretia as she commits suicide out of shame for her rape. No victims or survivors of sexual violence should ever have to go through that extra layer of pain and suffering. Our common duty is to understand what they have gone through, support and empower them and prevent such atrocities from ever happening again.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Kazakhstan.

Ms. Bakytbekkyzy (Kazakhstan): Kazakhstan thanks the United Kingdom presidency for convening today's open debate. We commend Special Representative Patten for the insights drawn from the Secretary-General's annual report on conflict-related sexual violence (*S/2023/413*), and we thank our civil-society briefers for their passionate plea to us and their horrifying analyses of that scourge in different parts of the world.

Kazakhstan endorses the recommendations of the Secretary-General's annual report. Despite the robust normative framework that has been established and the progress achieved, we need to collectively reflect on how to reduce conflict-related sexual violence. At the same time, we must take measures to ensure that sexual violence is not used as a tactic of war or aggravated by human trafficking, which can become a source of income for terrorist organizations and transnational organized crime networks. We also need to address

new and emerging threats from the largely ungoverned digital space. This scourge requires concerted and well-coordinated cross-national interventions with a One United Nations approach. There is also a need for improved coordination among United Nations entities, regional and subregional organizations and civil society in prevention, assistance to victims, research, advocacy, information-sharing, capacity-building and exchange of good practices in combating sexual violence.

An enhanced implementation of arms control and disarmament measures can contribute to both the long-term structural prevention and the short-term operational prevention of sexual violence in conflict. Our deliberations today make it clear that the international community should ensure accountability for sexual violence in conflict and bring a resolute end to impunity.

Conflict-related sexual violence affects every aspect of a survivor's life and leads to the stigmatization of victims and devastation of physical and economic security, especially of displaced and rural women. We therefore need a survivor-centred approach, which should include full, competent and speedy attention for the victims, with increased access to health care, psychosocial support, legal assistance and socioeconomic reintegration. Cooperation with religious leaders, civil society and local communities is most important to change extremist narratives, shift the stigma of sexual violence to the perpetrators, promote education and create awareness on the empowerment of women.

Kazakhstan strongly believes that preventing sexual exploitation and abuse by peacekeepers should be an absolute priority, with a United Nations zero-tolerance policy for such offences. All troop and police contingents should have full training prior to and during deployment. We support greater recruitment of well-qualified women military and police officers and the deployment of women's protection advisers to the peacekeeping missions.

Our country integrates all elements of the women and peace and security agenda, including on conflict-related sexual violence, in our national legislation, with new strong pro-women policies. Training on gender equality for the armed and security forces and women's deployment in United Nations peacekeeping operations are a priority for Kazakhstan at the Kazakhstan

Peace Operations Centre, our national peacekeeping training centre.

At the regional level, we are supporting Afghanistan with a multidimensional approach of conflict prevention and resolution, recovery and reintegration, accompanied by humanitarian and development assistance, through strengthening the security and development nexus. At the international level, we are contributing to the United Nations Trust Fund to End Violence against Women that funds projects in post-conflict settings.

To conclude, I reiterate Kazakhstan's strong commitment to fully implementing the women and peace and security agenda and promoting women's dignity and gender empowerment.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Cambodia.

Mr. Mao (Cambodia): First, my delegation would like to thank you, Mr. President, for convening today's debate on conflict-related sexual violence and promoting the implementation of Security Council resolutions on conflict-related sexual violence. We highly appreciate the Secretary-General's timely report on conflict-related sexual violence and the efforts of United Nations Action against Sexual Violence in Conflict. Allow me to also thank all the briefers and speakers before me for sharing their insights on the topic.

We all know that it is difficult to reduce conflict-related sexual violence when there are so many active conflicts and so much instability around the world. The trend of using sexual violence against women and girls as a means of terror and retribution is alarming. Therefore, I cannot agree more with the view of Ms. Pramila Patten, the Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict, that more actions are needed.

Allow me to highlight a few points.

First, on prevention, Member States should prioritize working together on the prevention of conflict and the escalation of existing conflicts. It is important to strengthen national legislation to ensure accountability for sexual crimes committed by members of the armed forces. Education and training with the involvement of women and victims should be mainstreamed within the armed forces, including those deployed as part of international peacekeeping missions.

Secondly, on victims' support, members of the armed forces should also be a part of the efforts to assist victims' recovery and integration. More women, especially those in the armed forces, should be encouraged to get involved in that endeavour.

Thirdly, enhancing accountability is the most difficult issue. Ideally, State or non-State actors condoning sexual abuse or weaponizing it for attrition or retribution should be made accountable. However, the challenges lie in the process being politicized, the question of victims' safety and the need for a victim-centred approach.

In conclusion, Cambodia strongly condemns all forms of sexual violence and calls for an end to all conflicts. We believe that conflict and instability are major factors that contribute to sexual violence and that peace and stability are essential to preventing that crime.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of India.

Mrs. Kamboj (India): We would like to express our gratitude to the United Kingdom for convening an open debate of the Security Council on conflict-related sexual violence. We also express our appreciation to Special Representative of the Secretary-General Pramila Patten and all the briefers for their valuable contribution and insightful perspectives.

Sexual violence in armed conflicts, perpetrated by State and non-State actors, poses grave security challenges. It is indeed disconcerting that sexual violence continues amid a thriving culture of impunity in armed conflicts. Over the past decade, the Security Council has put in place a strong framework to combat that menace, but the level of compliance by parties to the conflict remains alarmingly low. We feel that the Council must absolutely focus on identifying and bridging the implementation gaps to prevent such atrocities and facilitate the rehabilitation and reintegration of survivors.

Allow me to make six proposals very quickly.

First, national Governments have the primary responsibility for prosecuting and deterring such crimes in conflict situations in their territories, even if these are alleged to have been committed by non-State actors.

Secondly, Member States should ensure effective prosecution of sexual violence as a stand-alone crime.

There must be no impunity for the perpetrators, and States should ensure accountability, in line with their international obligations and their duty to uphold the rule of law.

Thirdly, the United Nations, upon request, must assist national authorities in conflict areas in developing capabilities to strengthen their national investigative and legal frameworks and related structures for the speedy investigation and prosecution of perpetrators.

Fourthly, as survivors of conflict-related sexual violence are not a homogenous group, countries must adopt a tailored, victim-centred approach to preventing and responding to sexual violence in armed conflicts, in line with resolution 2467 (2019), which calls for strengthening justice and accountability and for a survivor-centred approach in the prevention and response to conflict-related sexual violence.

Fifthly, States must ensure adequate focus and resources for comprehensive and non-discriminatory assistance for victims of sexual violence, by providing for, inter alia, medical, psychological, social and legal services.

Sixthly, sexual violence primarily directed against women and girls, and also against men and boys, by terrorists remains a cause of concern. The nexus between terrorism, trafficking and sexual violence in armed conflicts needs to be broken.

Going forward, we would recommend that a greater participation of women in conflict resolution and post-conflict reconciliation processes should be promoted to address deep-rooted inequality and subordination in society. It is important to make that a precondition for any peace process to succeed. In addition, mainstreaming the gender perspective in peace operations and increasing the representation of women in peacekeeping are prerequisites for prevention and response. In that way, India welcomes the United Nations uniformed gender-parity strategy to increase the number of women peacekeepers. We also support increasing the deployment of women protection advisers for effective monitoring, analysis and reporting arrangements on sexual violence in armed conflict. The experience of India's deployment of an all-women police contingent in Liberia illustrates the enormous positive impact that the deployment of women peacekeepers can have on the effective participation of women in civilian and political life in a post-conflict situation.

We would also add that if we are to promote synergy and effective coordination it is important to avoid duplication in the work of various United Nations bodies. The issue of violence against women, including sexual violence, is discussed in other United Nations bodies, including the Human Rights Council. Deliberations in the Security Council should therefore remain focused on such atrocities perpetrated in situations of armed conflict that threaten international peace and security. I strongly reaffirm India's unwavering commitment to actively contributing to our collective efforts to effectively address sexual violence in situations of armed conflict.

Lastly, I would also like to address the frivolous remarks made by a representative from another delegation concerning my country. I will not dwell on them for long, but I feel it necessary to dismiss such remarks with the contempt they deserve. A country that fails to safeguard the rights of its women and girls, allowing forced religious conversions and tolerating sexual and gender-based violence, has no credibility where passing judgment on any other nation is concerned, least of all my own.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Yemen.

Mr. Al-dobhany (Yemen) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I would like to thank you, Mr. President, for convening this important meeting. I also thank Special Representative of the Secretary-General Patten and the other briefers.

The Yemeni Government attaches great importance to women's issues. Very early on our Government developed a national plan on women and peace and security pursuant to resolution 1325 (2000), based on the four pillars of prevention, participation, protection and recovery. A normative framework and committees were established in collaboration with Government partners, including the National Committee on Women, law-enforcement agencies, civil-society organizations, academia and the private sector. Our Ministry of Social Affairs and Labour has organized and currently oversees the national team responsible for implementing the national plan and relevant activities.

Sexual violence is a degrading and heinous violation of human rights. It creates significant challenges to achieving the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development in the areas of gender equality, reducing inequality and

access to justice. That requires building effective and accountable institutions at all levels.

My country's delegation has taken note of the report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/413) on conflict-related sexual violence, and we thank Ms. Patten for her efforts. Yemen is committed to achieving peace and to positively and constructively implementing all regional and international efforts and endeavours, as well as those of the Special Envoy of the Secretary-General for Yemen, pursuant to the agreed terms of reference for a political solution. We affirm that the traditions and customs of Yemeni society proscribe any form of violation of the dignity of Yemeni women, and our national legislation criminalizes physical violence against women.

The Houthi militias have continued their numerous violations of international humanitarian law and international human rights law, which include violations harming women and girls and depriving them of their political, economic and social rights. Those violations have been documented in national reports and those of international human rights agencies, as well as the reports of the Panel of Experts on Yemen, most recently in 2022, as well as the report of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict for this year. They include the following.

First, the Houthi militias have discriminated against and marginalized women, imposing harsh restrictions on them in areas under their control. They have restricted their freedom of movement and forbidden them to travel abroad unless accompanied by a male. Women have been deprived of fundamental rights and subjected to severe social practices and gender-based segregation in schools and Government institutions, as well as being denied a quality education and the right to work outside the home and participate in public political and social life.

Secondly, with regard to sexual violence, we have documented many cases involving sexual exploitation and abuse committed by the Houthi militias against women and girls in areas under their control with the aim of terrorizing the population, in flagrant violation of international humanitarian law. One example is the arbitrary arrest and detention of Intisar Al-Hammadi and her colleagues, who were imprisoned, unfairly tried by Houthi militias, accused of indecent acts and

possession of narcotics and condemned to a five-year prison term.

Thirdly, there is the issue of arbitrary arrests and detention. The militias have been arresting women and girls without legal cause and based on false accusations, after which they are detained in secret prisons in harsh and inhumane conditions for their activities in the political, media or other arenas.

Fourthly, women and girls are seeing their fundamental freedoms violated, including freedom of expression, through defamation campaigns against women's rights defenders aimed at obstructing their work and undermining confidence in them and in the cases they are defending.

The Security Council's resolution 2564 (2021), on sanctions against Yemenis, has imposed sanctions on the Houthi leader Sultan Zabin, as a result of the horrendous and systematic campaign of arrests, detentions, torture, sexual violence and rape perpetrated against women and girls in areas under Houthi control. The resolution reaffirms the international community and the Security Council's refusal to tolerate practices of torture and sexual violence in areas under Houthi control, and it supports the rights of Yemeni women in those areas. We stress the importance of continuing to list the Houthi leaders who are responsible for such practices so that they are held accountable and so that justice can be served for the victims. Many women activists are still languishing in their prisons and undergoing physical torture, sexual violence and rape.

In conclusion, strengthening international cooperation to address conflict-related sexual violence is an important step towards achieving real and sustained change for women and girls by sharing information and expertise and providing technical and financial support for countries that are suffering in conflict or post-conflict situations. In that regard, we thank all of our regional and international partners, in particular the Government of Norway, which has supported Yemen in implementing and following up its national plan on women, peace and security by providing us with expertise and funds.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Ireland.

Ms. Kelly (Ireland): I thank our briefers today. We would like to take this opportunity to reiterate our steadfast commitment to Special Representative Patten

and to the work of her Office, which is so indispensable in shining a light on what is so often obscured. I commend the contribution of our civil-society briefers today, whose bravery is remarkable. They remind us that our approach to this most heinous of crimes must always be centred on survivors and prioritize their needs, perspectives and aspirations.

Ireland aligns itself with the statements made on behalf of the European Union, the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security and the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect.

As the Secretary-General outlines in his report (S/2023/413), 2022 has exposed civilians to heightened levels of sexual and gender-based violence against a backdrop of shrinking civil-society space and the collapse of the rule of law in conflict settings. Across the globe, whether in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Haiti, Myanmar, Ukraine or elsewhere, sexual and gender-based violence continues to be brandished as a weapon and tactic of war, and impunity regrettably remains the norm.

First and foremost, we repeat the call on all parties to conflict to immediately cease all forms of conflict-related sexual violence. Furthermore, all States should commit to a zero-tolerance policy for crimes of sexual and gender-based violence, in line with their obligations under international humanitarian law and international human rights law. That has been set out in numerous Security Council resolutions since the adoption of resolution 1820 (2008). Yet while our commitment to eliminating all forms of conflict-related sexual violence remains resolute on paper, translating that into reality remains a challenge. Civilians on the ground, mostly women and girls, continue to suffer, including in new and emerging manifestations, whether online, through the acts of mercenaries in private military companies or in gang warfare. Where acts of sexual and gender-based violence in conflict are ignored or even emboldened, that scourge will persist. Access to justice for survivors and accountability for perpetrators is absolutely essential. Though we have seen some encouraging developments in strengthening rule-of-law institutions and national legislations on protection and reparations, there remains much more to do in that space. In that regard, we welcome the recent launch of the legal guidebook on State obligations on conflict-related sexual violence.

Where national efforts fail, the international community, in particular the Security Council, has a duty to step up. Eight sanctions regimes of the Council include conflict-related sexual violence within their designation criteria. We believe that should be a prerequisite across all regimes and that the Council should continue to designate individuals who are specifically responsible for acts of sexual and gender-based violence, as done recently in Haiti and Yemen. The Council and its subsidiary bodies should continue close collaboration with the Special Representative and her Office and give due consideration to a dedicated field visit on the topic of conflict-related sexual violence. Critically, resource and budgetary commitments to deploying women protection advisers to United Nations missions and offices should match the political commitment we heard around this table today. Otherwise, we simply pay lip service to what is a serious threat, not just to individual security, but to international peace and security.

Finally, we wish to recognize the outstanding work undertaken by women-led organizations at the coalface, dealing with conflict-related sexual violence. Those organizations provide meaningful and sometimes life-saving support to survivors in the absence of more lasting solutions, often facing reprisals of their own. We encourage Member States to keep such organizations at the forefront of considerations in all humanitarian and development funding and efforts.

The President: I give the floor to the representative of Bangladesh.

Mr. Muhith (Bangladesh): I thank the presidency of the United Kingdom for organizing this important open debate. I also thank Ms. Pramila Patten, Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict and the other briefers for their comprehensive and insightful remarks.

Bangladesh aligns itself with the statements delivered by the representative of Canada on behalf of the Group of Friends of Women, Peace and Security and by the representative by Botswana on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect.

We had the horrific experience of sexual violence in conflict during our liberation war in 1971. More than 200,000 of our mothers and sisters were violated during that war. However, in a war-ravaged country with a lot of limitations, our father of the nation, Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, took immediate action to

meet the urgent needs of the victims and established a rehabilitation board for relief and reconstruction for war-affected women. The board arranged rehabilitation for the victims, including remedial measures to address physical and psychological trauma. In addition to the victim-support approach, most the perpetrators of the sexual violence have been brought to justice through a trial process. The contribution of victims to our independence has also been recognized officially.

In line with our commitment to preventing and stopping sexual violence in conflict, we have always been an ardent advocate and supporter of the women and peace and security agenda. We proudly recall that the Security Council adopted the historic and landmark resolution 1325 (2000) on women and peace and security in 2000, when Bangladesh was a member of the Council and played an important role in advancing the issue.

Regrettably, years later, we had to witness the worst form of sexual violence against the Rohingya in our neighbouring Myanmar. We have been providing all critical support to those 1.2 million Rohingya who have taken shelter in Bangladesh. Special Representative of the Secretary-General Pramila Patten has also visited the Rohingya camps in Cox's Bazar and heard first-hand from the victims. We have been repeatedly urging the Myanmar authorities to ensure the safe, voluntary and sustainable return of the Rohingya. Unfortunately, more than six years have passed, and no progress has been made towards their repatriation. Not a single Rohingya has returned, owing to a lack of conducive conditions in Myanmar. I refer to the Secretary-General's call to allow immediate and unconstrained access to United Nations-mandated investigatory and reporting bodies and humanitarian actors to provide support to the affected populations. At the same time, we would like to see the perpetrators of sexual violence held accountable in Myanmar.

It is unfortunate that sexual violence continues to be used as a tactic of war, torture and terrorism. The Secretary-General's latest report (S/2023/413) mentioned that, in most contexts, impunity remained the norm, while emerging threats in the largely ungoverned digital space and the combination of climate insecurity, State fragility and structural gender inequality further exposed women and girls to conflict-related sexual violence. In that context, allow me to highlight a few points.

First, States have the primary responsibility to prevent and respond to conflict-related sexual violence. In that connection, it is imperative to ensure the capacity-building of States to effectively address the root causes and to meet the needs of victims in order to reintegrate them into normal life. National action plans on women and peace and security can also play a critical role in the efforts of Member States to address sexual violence in conflict.

Secondly, we urge that the necessary steps be taken in addressing the gender-based digital divide. Gender-based hate speech and incitement to violence are fuelling conflicts in many places. At the same time, victims are disproportionately affected by the lack of access to digital tools and resources, hindering their access to life-saving security and public health information and networks, among others.

Thirdly, in addition to condemning that impunity for conflict-related sexual violence remains the norm, we need to ensure accountability through ensuring a gender-sensitive and efficient security and judicial sector and strengthening legal frameworks and justice mechanisms in national contexts. The Council needs to use its mandate and authority when national justice mechanisms are unable to deliver.

Fourthly, we highlight the role of United Nations peacekeepers in providing life-saving services and psychological support to the victims of conflict-related sexual violence in various war-ravaged zones. In that regard, we refer to the recommendation of the Secretary-General to include dedicated operational provisions on gender-responsive security and justice sector reform to prevent and respond to conflict-related sexual violence in the mandate authorizations and renewals of peace operations, as well as in transition plans. We also underscore the importance of the deployment of women's protection advisers to peace operations.

Fifthly, we call for greater coordination and complementarity among the United Nations mechanisms, especially in the reinvigorated resident coordinator system in the field, to complement the Council's work to address conflict-related sexual violence. We also call for greater synergies between the mandated United Nations entities and the Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women.

Finally, we underscore the role of the Peacebuilding Commission in helping to implement the Council's resolutions, including resolution 2467 (2019) through

its advice. The Peacebuilding Commission's advice can bring the voices of women briefers and women-led organizations to the Council.

The President: I give the floor to the representative of Morocco.

Mr. Hilale (Morocco) (*spoke in French*): First of all, my delegation would like to thank the United Kingdom for organizing this open debate on an issue of the utmost importance — that of eliminating sexual violence in times of conflict. I would also like to pay special tribute to the civil society representatives who shared their moving testimonies with us.

The Secretary-General's annual report (S/2023/413), published in June, shows that history is, unfortunately, repeating itself, with further cases of sexual violence, rape and torture, painting a picture of unacceptable savagery and brutality and laying out a chronicle of sexual violence in times of conflict.

Over the past decade, there has been a significant paradigm shift, and progress has been made, thanks in particular to the mandate of the Special Representative on Sexual Violence in Conflict and the relevant Security Council resolutions that succeeded resolution 1325 (2000). Today, sexual violence in armed conflict and post-conflict situations is considered a threat to international peace and security.

However, given that those abhorrent acts have persisted, indignation is no longer enough. We need to step up our collective action and come up with true solutions that are pragmatic and, above all, sustainable, to prevent and punish acts of sexual violence and help survivors to rebuild their lives and reintegrate fully into their communities, while also preserving their rights and dignity. In this respect, let me highlight the following points.

First, the international community would benefit from a more comprehensive and holistic approach, which prevents conflicts and addresses their root causes. Conflict prevention is a central pillar not only of the women and peace and security agenda, but also of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, whose Sustainable Development Goals, particularly Goals 5 and 16, place great emphasis on conflict prevention and prove that women's issues, peace, security and development are linked, interconnected and inseparable.

Secondly, women must be included in decision-making processes, in particular by promoting and encouraging national initiatives aimed at ending gender-based discrimination. It is also crucial that women's participation in debates on conflict resolution, the maintenance of peace and security, and post-conflict peacebuilding is supported.

Thirdly, we need to fight impunity, enshrine a zero-tolerance policy and ensure access to justice for victims. At the same time, the stigma surrounding victims of sexual violence, and the children born of such violence, must be corrected, as it constitutes a new form of victimization. They need to be provided with medical care and reintegrated socially and economically.

Finally, religious leaders have an influential role to play in combating the abuse of religion to justify gender-based violence and discrimination. They must be encouraged to speak out strongly against these heinous crimes. In addition, local actors and community leaders have their own crucial role to play, as they can identify the warning signs of sexual violence, create early-warning systems and propose appropriate prevention strategies.

The Kingdom of Morocco strongly condemns all forms of sexual violence, including in times of conflict, and considers them to be barbaric, brutal and inhumane methods and practices, with serious consequences for the process of establishing lasting peace and reconciliation. Convinced of women's contribution as crucial early-warning mechanisms, given their awareness of threats to local security and their role in mediation, Morocco actively participates in a number of initiatives, including the promotion of mediation in the Mediterranean, the Women, Peace and Security Focal Points Network, and the Mediterranean Women Mediators Network.

Furthermore, since the creation of the Royal Armed Forces in 1956, and the early integration of female personnel into it, the inclusion of women in the Moroccan military has grown increasingly. Indeed, His Majesty King Mohammed VI, Supreme Commander and Chief of the General Staff of the Royal Armed Forces, has granted high-level instructions that authorize female personnel to take part in the competitive entrance examination to the higher military academies under the same conditions as their male counterparts. As a result, Moroccan military women now serve in the National Defence Administration and in all components of the

Royal Armed Forces, namely, the Air Force, the Navy and the Royal Gendarmerie. Finally, women are also present in the United Nations peacekeeping missions in which Moroccan contingents are deployed, in particular in the Democratic Republic of Congo and the Central African Republic.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Ethiopia.

Mr. Yoseph (Ethiopia): We thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for her briefing this morning.

Taking note of the report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/413), we would like to convey our thanks to the Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for the participatory working methods and consultations that allowed us to react to the draft report prior to its finalization. However, it is regrettable that, despite our engagement, the report does not incorporate our inputs and serious concerns.

For that reason, I would like to put on record our strong reservations about the scope and content of the report where it deals with Ethiopia as well as its reference to the International Commission of Human Rights Experts on Ethiopia. We do not recognize this Commission and any of its substandard work. We therefore caution the Special Representative of the Secretary-General from using such dubious sources.

In the last two years, Ethiopia was faced with extraordinary security challenges. Despite these challenges, the Government of Ethiopia has made concerted efforts to ensure, respect and protect the rights of women in vulnerable situations. Unhindered humanitarian aid has been expedited to all people in need of assistance. The implementation of the November 2022 peace agreement has enabled the further provision of humanitarian aid, and the restoration of services and the disarmament, demobilization and reintegration of former combatants are now under way.

We have also charted a clear path for accountability for alleged human rights violations. On women's rights, we followed a four-tiered approach that encompasses accountability and victim support. The first of these tiers is the Inter-Ministerial Task Force (IMTF), which is implementing the recommendations of the joint investigation report of the Ethiopian Human Rights Commission and the Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights. The second tier involves the military

justice system, which ensures accountability through its own mechanisms. In this process, we have pending and closed prosecutions against suspected perpetrators of alleged crimes against women. The third tier consists of the regular law-enforcement mechanisms that are coordinated with the IMTF on the prosecution of suspects and the provision of remedies for victims. The fourth tier involves the work of the Ethiopian Ministry of Women and Social Affairs, which leads cross-sectional initiatives to provide rehabilitation and comprehensive support for victims.

All the foregoing processes will further be consolidated in the mechanisms to be established under the transitional justice policy. The options for this transitional justice policy are being discussed in nationwide consultations. It is expected that the policy will take its final form in August and that implementation will start in September. The Ethiopian Human Rights Commission and the Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights are providing technical assistance to ensure these consultations conform to international standards.

Our reconstruction and recovery programmes have also given adequate place for such sectors such as health, education, and the economy, and have a special focus on women. We have also intensified our efforts aimed at providing psychological support, legal assistance and socioeconomic support.

Finally, I would like to reiterate that Ethiopia has an unwavering commitment to the respect, protection and fulfilment of all the human rights of women and to women's equal and meaningful participation in all political processes. It is on this basis that we will further scrutinize the report with a view to addressing any relevant aspects of the recommendations contained therein. While we commit to continuing our engagement with her Office, we hope that the Special Representative will sufficiently reflect on the inputs we provide and operate within her defined scope.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Thailand.

Mr. Chindawongse (Thailand): At the outset, Thailand wishes to express its appreciation to the United Kingdom for convening today's open debate on the important issue of conflict-related sexual violence. I also thank the Secretary-General for his recent report (S/2023/413) as well as all the briefers for their contributions.

Despite all the efforts that we have made towards the elimination of all acts of violence against civilians in armed conflict, it is clear from the report of the Secretary-General that conflict-related sexual violence remains persistent and widespread. This sad reality is also echoed in his annual report on children and armed conflict (S/2023/363), which was distributed just last month. Girls continue to be disproportionately affected by sexual violence in conflicts. This cannot continue.

Thailand unequivocally condemns sexual violence, both in times of conflict and in times of peace, as well as the use of sexual violence as a weapon of war. The growing trend of such criminal acts is indeed worrisome, and more should be done to address this issue.

We strongly believe that the international community and all parties involved in conflict must strengthen their efforts to implement the relevant Security Council resolutions adopted to ensure the protection of civilians. In that regard, I wish to highlight the following four points.

First, prevention is key. Thailand believes that the protection and promotion of women's rights, the empowerment of women and the advancement of gender equality are fundamental elements in combating sexual violence. Therefore, it is essential to reduce pre-existing structural inequalities, eradicate all forms of discrimination and combat extreme poverty among women and girls. We need to recognize that their meaningful participation within our societies as active agents of change is fundamental for our prevention efforts.

Secondly, we must protect and guarantee the rights of survivors of conflict-related sexual violence. To avoid the marginalization and stigmatization of victims, survivor-centred approaches need to be employed to ensure their access to services and justice. In parallel, effective investigation and prosecution of sexual violence crimes need to be reinforced to hold the perpetrators accountable, as well as to prevent the recurrence of that human rights violation.

Thirdly, Thailand wishes to reiterate its full support to the women and peace and security agenda and continues to look for ways to strengthen its commitment. We fully recognize the role of women as security providers and peacebuilders, not just as victims. Specific measures should be undertaken to ensure women's full, equal and meaningful participation at all levels of peace and security dialogues and processes.

In that connection, we support the recommendation to increase the deployment of women peacekeepers in line with the Uniformed Gender Parity Strategy 2018-2028. We commend the work of women's protection advisers in all United Nations peacekeeping operations and special political missions and encourage their further deployment.

Fourth and lastly, as a troop- and police-contributing country, Thailand adheres to the policy of zero tolerance of sexual exploitation and abuse in United Nations peacekeeping operations. In the meantime, we are convinced that all military and police personnel throughout the entire chain of command, regardless of their gender, should receive adequate training to effectively prevent and respond to sexual violence. In that regard, Thailand supports the call to provide technical support and capacity-building for troop- and police-contributing countries through both predeployment and in-mission training.

In conclusion, sexual violence against people of any gender, whether in times of conflict or peace, has no justification. We all must do our part and step up our efforts to end the cycles of sexual violence in all instances once and for all.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Australia.

Ms. Webster (Australia): Australia thanks the United Kingdom for convening today's open debate and for its continued leadership on conflict-related sexual violence.

Notwithstanding the many Security Council resolutions and the comprehensive nature of States' obligations under international humanitarian law and international human rights law, women and girls continue to be subjected to sexual violence in conflict-affected settings, including in Afghanistan, Myanmar, Ukraine and the Sudan.

Australia strongly condemns the harassment, the use of force and rape as instruments of repression and political intimidation against women peacebuilders and human rights defenders. The targeting of public health facilities, impeding access to services for survivors, is unacceptable.

Australia's commitment to eliminating sexual violence in conflict is long-standing. We are committed to addressing technology-facilitated gender-based

violence, delivering justice and holding perpetrators to account.

We welcome the deployment of women's protection advisers in United Nations peacekeeping missions. Australia's Defence Force, Federal Police and Department of Foreign Affairs train and deploy gender advisers on military, police, humanitarian, relief and recovery and crisis operations and missions. We also prioritize efforts to create more diverse and inclusive military and police institutions, through our support to the Elsie Initiative Fund and UN-Women, to accelerate the meaningful representation of uniformed women across all levels of United Nations peace operations. Australia is also a founding member of the Call to Action on Protection from Gender-Based Violence in Emergencies.

Survivors of conflict-related sexual violence are not a homogenous group; hence, the need for responding to intersecting forms of discrimination and tailored, survivor-centred action. That includes employing the Murad Code and ensuring that persons subjected to sexual violence in conflict have access to safe, comprehensive support and services.

We encourage Member States to promote accountability for sexual and gender-based violence and the Security Council to continue to counter impunity with all the means at its disposal. We are particularly concerned about the link between private military security companies and reports of sexual violence. Existing frameworks, such as the Montreux Document, are important tools to help close the gap on attribution and accountability.

Efforts to prevent and resolve conflict cannot be separated from efforts to address sexual and gender-based violence. We must do more. We must implement the Security Council resolutions that condemn conflict-related sexual violence and fully implement the women and peace and security agenda.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Argentina.

Ms. Squeff (Argentina) (*spoke in Spanish*): We are grateful for the convening of this important open debate and for the briefings by Special Representative Pramila Patten and the representatives of civil society. We are also grateful for the work undertaken by Ms. Patten.

Throughout history, rape and sexual violence have been used as weapons of war and often as a

deliberate strategy in the conduct of hostilities. Since the adoption of resolution 1820 (2008), there has been a growing public awareness of those crimes and their consequences. Sexual violence perpetuates conflict and instability. Its long-term, destructive nature has devastating effects, not only on the survivors of this crime but on entire communities.

Despite numerous international instruments calling for the protection of civilians from sexual assault in armed conflict and recognizing that such acts can constitute war crimes, conflict-related sexual violence continues to prevail in a culture of near total impunity.

Conflict-related sexual violence may be exacerbated in contexts where extreme gender inequality prevails, contributing to its normalization. Gender inequality is both an underlying cause of sexual crimes and an obstacle to their prevention. Preventing systematic and widespread sexual violence begins in peacetime with the adoption of national laws that are sufficiently robust in terms of criminalizing such behaviour. States must have legislative mechanisms and judicial institutions that are prepared to comprehensively address that issue.

Crimes associated with sexual violence have a gendered impact. The discussions of those crimes typically focus on violence perpetrated by men against women and girls. However, we must expand discussions to include the impacts of those criminal acts when they are also directed against men, boys and LGBTIQ+ persons. In such cases, there is a high level of underreporting, which, coupled with reprisals, discrimination and stigmatization, contributes to widespread impunity for perpetrators.

Holding perpetrators of sexual violence to account is vital to ensure justice for victims and as deterrence for the perpetration of future crimes. Perpetrators of such crimes can be individually prosecuted under international law, and States have a primary obligation to do so. When a State is unwilling or unable to investigate and prosecute international crimes, including conflict-related sexual violence, the international community should take the necessary measures to refer the situation to the International Criminal Court. The Rome Statute clearly criminalizes rape and any other form of sexual violence as war crimes and crimes against humanity.

One area where acts of sexual violence occur is in schools or on routes to and from schools. Resolution 2601 (2021) on the protection of education during armed conflict expresses concern about the consequences of

attacks that women and girls may suffer, including rape and other forms of sexual violence, which may prevent them from continuing their education. In that regard, we want to draw attention to the Safe Schools Declaration, which is an intergovernmental political commitment to ensuring safe education and preventing sexual violence in conflict. We therefore encourage all States that have not yet done so to subscribe to the Declaration, which has already been endorsed by more than 100 countries.

In conclusion, we would like to remind the Council that in 2015, at the initiative of Argentina and the United Kingdom, the General Assembly adopted resolution 69/293, proclaiming 19 June the International Day for the Elimination of Sexual Violence in Conflict, with a view to raising awareness of the need to end conflict-related sexual violence, honour the victims and survivors of sexual violence and pay tribute to all who have bravely dedicated their lives to the struggle to end such crimes and have lost their lives in that endeavour.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of the Islamic Republic of Iran.

Mr. Ahmadi (Islamic Republic of Iran): I thank the briefers for their input.

Armed conflict has a devastating and disproportionate impact on women and girls, making them the primary victims of violence, displacement and human rights violations. The use of sexual violence as a tactic in such conflicts is an abhorrent crime that disproportionately affects women and girls, who bear the brunt of its horrific brutality. Iran strongly condemns all forms of sexual violence perpetrated during armed conflict and calls on all parties to armed conflicts to comply with their obligations under international law. Within our volatile region of the Middle East, the threats posed by foreign occupation and interference and terrorism put the rights and safety of women in grave jeopardy and disregard their security needs.

Addressing such inhumane practices requires a collaborative approach. The Security Council resolutions relevant to armed conflict explicitly underscore the imperative of combating conflict-related sexual violence and emphasizing accountability for those heinous acts. The primary goal is to foster an environment that effectively prevents and responds to such violence while safeguarding and empowering victims. However, achieving success in prevention hinges on addressing the root causes, and primarily the conflicts themselves. Consequently, the ultimate

solution for curbing such crimes lies in the complete elimination of armed conflict. Unfortunately, as long as terrorism, violent extremism and foreign occupation and interference persist, that will continue to be elusive. Meanwhile, we should concentrate our efforts on advancing women's empowerment initiatives, such as enhancing access to education, economic opportunities and health-care services.

Besides that, specific measures such as strengthening the rule of law, ensuring the effective functioning of justice systems and providing comprehensive support to victims are pivotal in protecting women and girls from sexual violence during armed conflict. It is also equally vital to promote accountability, which is a crucial aspect in addressing conflict-related sexual violence. It is critical for the international community to respond decisively, particularly in cases where those reprehensible crimes are perpetrated by foreign occupying forces in conflict zones.

In conclusion, we categorically refute the groundless allegations and unjustified references made about Iran in the Secretary-General's recent report on sexual violence in armed conflict (S/2023/413). The allegations are absolutely false, made without solid evidence and based solely on unreliable and distorted information from media sources. Considering the report's specific focus on sexual violence in armed conflict, it is deeply concerning that the Special Representative has overstepped her mandate by making unfounded claims about a Member State that have nothing to do with armed conflict. We strongly object to and condemn such irresponsible actions, which undermine the integrity of the report and of the United Nations in general.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Myanmar.

Mr. Tun (Myanmar): At the outset, I would like to thank the United Kingdom for organizing this annual debate on the important issue of conflict-related sexual violence. I also thank Special Representative Patten and the civil-society representatives, including Ms. Naw Hser Hser from Myanmar, for their insightful briefings this morning.

This year's report of the Secretary-General on conflict-related sexual violence (S/2023/413) informs us about the worrying trends in sexual violence across the world. In many situations, including that of my own country, Myanmar, civilians have been exposed

to higher levels of sexual violence as a result of the collapse of the rule of law and the escalation of conflict following unconstitutional changes of Government. Patterns of sexual violence have deepened, and sexual violence has continued to be used as a deliberate tactic of war. It has also been used in the context of political violence to intimidate and punish opponents. Impunity remains pervasive.

It has long been documented and is well known to the United Nations that the Myanmar military has used sexual violence, such as rape and gang rape, as a tactic of war during conflict. The security and police forces under the direct control of the illegitimate military junta have been systematically using sexual violence as a tactic of war, political oppression, intimidation and retaliation since the illegal military coup in February 2021. Ms. Naw Hser Hser informed the Council about the true and devastating situation in Myanmar, especially the heartbreaking situation that women and girls are facing. I want to take this opportunity to thank and salute Ms. Naw Hser Hser and all women human rights defenders for their tireless efforts and bravery in protecting women and girls and promoting their rights. Echoing what Ms. Naw Hser Hser said earlier this morning, I appeal to the military junta and its supporters not to kill or harm people.

It is clear and certain that the people of Myanmar, particularly women and girls, are facing severe suffering caused by the military junta. I have repeatedly informed the Council and the General Assembly that the violence and atrocities that the junta has committed since the coup are not isolated incidents. They are so widespread, targeted and systematic that the Independent Investigative Mechanism for Myanmar concluded that they could amount to crimes against humanity and war crimes. I appreciate the fact that the Secretary-General and Special Representative Patten have rightly included the Myanmar military, including its border guard, on the list in this year's report of parties credibly suspected of committing or being responsible for patterns of rape or other forms of sexual violence in situations of armed conflict.

On the other hand, the National Unity Government of Myanmar, in line with the Federal Democracy Charter, has taken a people-centred approach to advancing the women and peace and security agenda through civic actors. The National Unity Government has been doing its best in every way to make sure that its People's Defence Force adheres to the rules

of engagement and to international humanitarian and human rights law.

Women and girls in Myanmar, particularly those in conflict areas, need protection from the military's sexual violence. The survivors deserve justice. The junta is unwilling to address the sexual violence being committed by its personnel. Instead, it maintains a culture of impunity among the rank and file. To put an end to this heinous crime of sexual violence in Myanmar, we must transform the military institution from the main sexual violence perpetrator to a professional and accountable institution that is subject to the rule of law and democratic oversight, as well as to federal democratic norms and principles. That is a key goal of our ongoing revolution against the military dictatorship in Myanmar.

I agree with and endorse the demands made earlier today by civil society representative Ms. Naw Hser Hser, for the further action of the Security Council. In addition, I wish to make the following appeal.

It is important that the United Nations system continue to work with and support women-led organizations, women civil society organization leaders and human rights defenders in monitoring and documenting the sexual violence situation in Myanmar and assisting survivors in every possible way. All individual Member States should support Myanmar women, among others, by giving protection to those who fled the junta's atrocities and by supporting women-led organizations and initiatives. The Security Council should give serious attention to the situation of women and girls in Myanmar, especially in conflict-affected areas. It should demand an immediate end to sexual violence being committed by the military. More importantly, the Council should take concrete actions to end military impunity.

Those specific demands should be included in an enforceable follow-up resolution to resolution 2669 (2022). I therefore wish to urge the members of the Security Council to start a negotiation process now to adopt a timely and enforceable resolution on Myanmar.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Cyprus.

Mr. Hadjichrysanthou (Cyprus): At the outset, I would like to thank the British presidency of the Security Council for the timely organization of today's meeting on the important issue of conflict-related

sexual violence, as well as the Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict for her insightful briefing. We reiterate our full support for her mandate. We also congratulate the members of civil society, who made invaluable contributions today.

My delegation fully subscribes to the statement delivered by the representative of the European Union. I would like to make some additional remarks in my national capacity.

Cyprus strongly condemns gender-based violence in all its forms and manifestations, online and offline, including all acts of sexual violence against civilians in armed conflict. Despite the progress made since the unanimous adoption of resolution 1820 (2008) by the Security Council in 2008, the abhorrent crime of conflict-related sexual violence continues, and impunity, regrettably, prevails in many cases. Victims and survivors are often living ashamed in the shadows, awaiting justice and redress.

We are deeply concerned about the growing use of sexual violence as a tactic of war, torture and terrorism, including the severity and brutality of such incidents. Numbers cannot lie and are only the tip of the iceberg, since many cases remain unreported. These heinous crimes of conflict-related sexual violence can also be facilitated and promoted online, utilizing digital channels. We note with concern that women and girls, constituting the majority of the victims of conflict-related sexual violence, are disproportionately affected by the gender digital divide.

Cyprus recalls that rape and other forms of sexual violence can constitute a war crime, a crime against humanity or a constitutive act with respect to genocide. Conflict-related sexual violence is a peace and security issue and an impediment to the restoration of peace, requiring specific operational and policy responses.

These heinous crimes should not remain unanswered and cannot be addressed in isolation. Member States have obligations under international humanitarian law and international human rights law. It is their responsibility to prevent and address such violence, protect and support survivors and bring perpetrators to justice. In that regard, Cyprus joins others in calling all parties to armed conflict, including non-State armed groups, to cease acts of sexual violence against civilians immediately and completely and to implement action plans to prevent and address sexual violence, in accordance with their obligations

under international humanitarian law and all relevant Security Council resolutions.

Prosecution and accountability are key to ensuring long-lasting peace. Therefore, we need to strengthen legal procedures at the national, regional and international levels, ensuring that all victims of sexual violence, particularly women and girls, have equal protection under the law and equal access to justice.

Addressing the culture of impunity is our common responsibility. The international community also has an obligation to ensure accountability for such crimes when national institutions are unable or unwilling to do so. The Security Council must use all tools at its disposal to support action against conflict-related sexual violence as a tactic of war.

A survivor-centred approach must guide all our actions and responses to conflict-related sexual violence. We should always take into consideration that survivors are not a homogenous group. They have different needs and perspectives that we need to take into consideration in addressing the trauma that victims, survivors and their families are experiencing, including by ensuring access to medical care and psychosocial support.

As a country that has experienced the atrocity of conflict-related sexual violence first-hand, Cyprus attaches great importance to the elimination of all forms of gender-based violence and joins calls to accelerate efforts towards their elimination. In that regard, Cyprus has adopted action plans and strategies related to gender equality, including legislative measures, highlighting and promoting the positive role of women as agents of change.

It is imperative to address the root causes of sexual violence in conflict settings and of gender-based violence, which is deeply rooted in historical inequalities that perpetuate the problem. In that regard, the full, equal and meaningful participation and involvement of women in all efforts for the maintenance of peace and security is a sine qua non for the full implementation of the peace and security agenda, including in addressing conflict-related sexual violence.

To conclude, Cyprus remains committed to continuing to work with the international community to strengthen the global response to conflict-related sexual violence in order to protect and empower women, girls, men and boys, in all their diversity.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Iraq.

Mr. Marzooq (Iraq) (*spoke in Arabic*): My country's delegation would like to wish the United Kingdom delegation every success in presiding over the Council this month. We also express our thanks to the sisterly United Arab Emirates for its successful presidency of the Council last month. We thank as well Ms. Pramila Patten, Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict, for her briefing.

Iraq was one of the first Arab countries to develop a national plan for the implementation of resolution 1325 (2000) for the meaningful and effective participation of women. My country's delegation would like to highlight several government measures that were taken in that regard.

First, the 2021 electoral law allowed Iraqi women to enter the elections as candidates. That led to 97 women being voted into Parliament, which exceeded the women's quota.

Secondly, the National Strategy for Iraqi Women 2023–2030 was launched. It includes participation, protection, economic empowerment and social elements.

Thirdly, we have established centres for protection from domestic violence, and work is under way to develop standardized regulations to govern the work of those centres.

Fourth, we are working to ensure the prosecution of perpetrators of conflict-related sexual violence, together with a zero-tolerance policy for their actions. They are not entitled to any form of amnesty that has been granted.

Fifth, in terms of the progress made in applying the law on compensating Yazidi women survivors, the Government of Iraq has begun setting up a database of women and girls entitled to compensation under the law. Moreover, since March, the Directorate for Survivor Affairs has been disbursing the first round of stipends awarded to women survivors. We are working on listing all remaining survivors in the database.

Sixth, around 72,000 national identification documents have been issued to women and children, as well as internally displaced persons, in the liberated areas.

Seventh, the Directorate for Survivor Affairs is implementing a referral system, in collaboration with 10 specialized psychosocial support organizations, to provide support services to women survivors for their rehabilitation and reintegration into society.

Eighth, Iraq has continued to deal with the aftermath of the actions of the terrorist organization Da'esh, and we are striving to provide and uphold justice for the victims and their families. We stress the importance of delivering justice as quickly as possible, as any protracted deferral would contribute to impunity for the perpetrators and undermine justice. In that regard, my delegation stresses the importance and the need for the United Nations Investigative Team to Promote Accountability for Crimes Committed by Da'esh/Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant to provide the Iraqi judiciary with all the evidence that it has gathered pursuant to its mandate so that we can move forward and immediately prosecute suspects fairly and transparently.

In conclusion, while we condemn all the heinous crimes perpetrated by Da'esh, we do not support exploiting the latest report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/413) by including inappropriate wording in it.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Namibia.

Mrs. Kuzee (Namibia): Namibia thanks the United Kingdom presidency for organizing this debate on women and peace and security. As a champion of the women and peace and security agenda, we are as always encouraged by the overwhelming support for this annual open debate.

Conflict-related sexual violence is a serious and abhorrent crime that implies a collective moral obligation and provokes a sense of urgency. It is therefore worrying that despite the fact that the Security Council has adopted resolutions recognizing conflict-related sexual violence as a tactic of war and terrorism, that violence persists and in some situations has even increased, with impunity remaining the norm. Conflict-related sexual violence occurs on a continuum of interrelated and recurring forms of violence against women and girls, and the consequences for victims and their communities are both immediate and long-term. It not only violates the human rights of its victims, it also devastates families and communities, with the effects of those crimes echoing across generations, manifested through gender inequalities, trauma, stigma, poverty

and poor health and well-being. In Africa that seriously affects our potential to harness the demographic dividend, as it impedes the potential of women and girls.

Impunity means that children and young adults learn that sexual violence is acceptable and that regressive and violent customs and practices reappear. Resolution 2467 (2019) reminds us that it is the responsibility of States to end impunity and to prosecute those responsible for crimes of genocide, crimes against humanity and war crimes perpetrated against civilians, including conflict-related sexual violence. In seeking to bridge the existing implementation gaps, we must ensure gender mainstreaming in peacekeeping and peacebuilding; sensitize forces participating in peacekeeping missions on gender issues and ensure that gender sensitization is part of the preparation of troops and police who are participating in peacekeeping missions; advocate for more women to be included in peacekeeping missions at all levels of decision-making and peacekeeping processes; ensure that personnel deployed to conflict areas are aware of the causes of the conflict and of effective strategies of conflict management and that measures are in place to hold members of peacekeeping forces accountable for the commission of conflict-related sexual violence or other violations, such as sexual exploitation, rape and other forms of gender-based violence.

The women and peace and security agenda was born out of the need to promote women's participation in efforts and processes aimed at pursuing peace and security, the prevention of all forms of violence against women and girls and the protection of women in conflict and non-conflict situations, as well as the need to position women not merely as victims but as key actors in the development of gender-responsive peace and security policies and programming. As we continue to drive forward action on women and peace and security and conflict-related sexual violence, we must ensure that the rights and needs of the survivors of sexual violence are at the heart of response efforts and interventions.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Georgia.

Mr. Abesadze (Georgia): I would like to express our appreciation to the United Kingdom presidency for its leadership in bringing this important issue to the forefront of today's discussions. We also thank the Secretary-General for his latest report (S/2023/413).

Georgia aligns itself with the statement made on behalf of the European Union earlier today, and I would like to add some comments in my national capacity.

Unfortunately, sexual violence continues to be used as a strategy of warfare and a tactic of terror, shattering lives and scarring communities. It is often present in military conflicts and has an immense impact on innocent civilians. It is a horrendous crime that affects all people, although it disproportionately impacts women and girls. We are concerned about the findings of the Secretary-General's report on violations in several countries. We condemn the documented cases of sexual violence and of its use as a method of torture by Russian forces and Russian-affiliated armed groups in Ukraine.

Research and experience have shown that conflict-related sexual and gender-based violence is not an inevitable by-product of war. It can be prevented. Eliminating sexual violence during conflict must be a priority for the international community. It can be prevented by strengthening national and international efforts, raising awareness and ensuring justice. The Security Council's resolutions on conflict-related sexual violence have paved the way for States to establish a firm normative framework that can address such violence as an issue of peace and security. With that in mind, the Government of Georgia joined more than 50 States at the Preventing Sexual Violence in Conflict Initiative Conference, held in London last year, and endorsed its political declaration, aimed at urgently accelerating action to end conflict-related sexual violence, hold those responsible to account, shatter the existing culture of impunity, provide more comprehensive support to survivors and tackle stigma. I would like to take this opportunity to commend the United Kingdom for the successful outcome of the Conference.

Furthermore, at the Conference Georgia undertook national commitments outlining steps to address conflict-related sexual violence by contributing to a strengthened global response, implementing policies and programmes to tackle the harmful gender stereotypes that drive such violence, strengthening justice for conflict-related sexual violence and

supporting survivors and children born as a result of that violence. Moreover, the promotion of women's rights and gender equality, including in the military, remains among my Government's top priorities. The gender-equality strategy of the Ministry of Defence of Georgia has established the conditions needed to guarantee equal rights, freedoms and opportunities for men and women, prevent and eradicate all forms of discrimination, counter all forms of gender violence and eradicate misconduct, sexual harassment and physical and psychological mistreatment. The Georgian Ministry of Defence is also continuing its efforts to increase peacekeeping personnel's capacity to prevent and respond to sexual and gender-based violence, including in conflict and post-conflict situations. All personnel deployed to peacekeeping missions are familiarized with the Security Council resolutions on women and peace and security within the framework of mandatory predeployment trainings. I would like to add that in October 2022, the Georgian Government adopted its most recent national action plan for the period from 2022 to 2024 on the implementation of resolution 1325 (2000).

However, the illegal occupation of Georgia's Abkhazia and Tskhinvali/South Ossetia regions by the Russian Federation remains the main obstacle to the Georgian Government's implementation of the human rights protection framework for the women and girls who remain on the other side of the illegally erected barbed-wire fences. They are systematically subjected to human rights violations, including the denial of the right to freedom of movement, threats to their physical security for so-called illegal border crossings and illegal detentions. Recently, there has been an extremely worrisome pattern observed: an increased targeting of Georgian women. The outrageous practice of illegal detentions is being used as an instrument of terror against one of the most vulnerable groups. International engagement and monitoring of the situation inside the conflict-affected regions, and the Russia-occupied regions of Georgia in particular, is therefore paramount for ensuring substantive gender equality and preventing sexual violence against women.

The meeting rose at 6.40 p.m.